El Oro de los Tigres

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An Old Umbrella

4TH-01

El oro de los tigres

An Old Umbrella

Druvis Ⅲ: ...!

Druvis Ⅲ: Vertin ...

Through the window, she sees a beam of light penetrates the statue suspended in time.

Druvis Ⅲ: I saw ... Vertin ... by the "Storm" ...!

Druvis Ⅲ: ... No.

Druvis Ⅲ: It's just a nightmare.

Druvis Ⅲ: ...

The slender figure gets up. The lobby is as spacious as it used to be, but she's the only being walking across it now.

Druvis Ⅲ: A nightmare overly real.

Druvis Ⅲ: Is it because I haven't seen them for so long?

Rarely this place would be in such serenity.

Since their return to the Foundation, each one of them has been invited to a one-on-one talk with the Foundation's personnel.

Druvis Ⅲ: Vertin ... was the first to leave.

Druvis Ⅲ: She said she was going to talk to Madam Z about which department we would belong to. I haven't heard from her since then.

Vertin: Yes. Here are their background reports I wrote for your perusal.

Druvis Ⅲ: Then, Sotheby.

Druvis Ⅲ: Her boredom was swept away by the invitation. She departed in such a haste that her beloved doll was left behind on the carpet.

Vertin: This is Sotheby. A well-educated lady born in a traditional arcanist family.

Vertin: She comes from an extremely privileged background. Her family had a special influence around the world.

Vertin: Besides, she has limited social skills and scientific knowledge. It will be difficult to assimilate her.

Druvis Ⅲ: Compared to Sotheby, Mr. APPLe was apparently not very happy to be invited. When he left, he turned a little green.

Vertin: Mr. APPLe, under his modest and gentle appearance, lies a sharp perception by nature.

Vertin: Being so erudite, he always has his own views of our historical intelligence.

Vertin: As far as I know, he remains upset about Captain Regulus's involuntary affiliations with the Foundation.

Vertin: While Regulus has never been truly accepted by the Foundation.

Vertin: She has missed out all the education and training a member of the Foundation should have received. The influence left by the outside world on her is like a banner among the ordinary staff in the Foundation. A banner way too salient.

Vertin: Once the banner was held up, new arguments were raised, and thus exacerbated the factional conflict inside the Foundation.

Z: Factional conflict? There ought to be no factions in the Foundation. All of us share one common goal. You should know that well.

Vertin: But the conflict has been there all the time.

Vertin: And it only grows.

Z: ...

Vertin: The group that believes in "mankind supremacy" is splitting the Foundation's belief apart.

Z: ... So, time isn't the only thing you've been observing these years.

Vertin: The conflicts cannot be covered by regulations anymore, Madam Z.

Vertin: The "Storm" has been here for 8 years. None of the people who are left behind can shake off the influence it brought.

Vertin: Human technologies are being reversed, while arcanum is blooming.

Vertin: The unexpected first "Storm" brought more than half of the Foundation's elite members away from us. The number of staff of the House of Integratus and the Committee cannot compare with that of their heyday even now.

Vertin: In order to contend against Manus Vindictae, we have kept absorbing arcanists from the outside world ... However, the dissenting voices have only grown louder ...

Vertin: Loud enough to be heard, and have become a faction that couldn't be shaken—the Mankind Caucus.

Vertin: Beyond their control, these new arcanists only brought fear. They demand an unchallengeable power to make decisions and a harsher control of arcanists.

Vertin: Madam Z, I don't want my friends or me to be the sacrifice of this conflict ... As we were four years ago.

Z: ...

Z: That's why you handed in the background reports of those arcanists as the evidence for your proposition in the negotiation.

Z: Vertin, what do you want?

Vertin: A neutral, safe, and legitimate place for us.

Z: What if I'm also on the side of Mankind Caucus?

Vertin: I don't know whose side you are on. But I believe the future you pursue doesn't end up with the Foundation being split apart by factional conflict.

Z: ...

Vertin: That's what I learnt from that stormy night.

Vertin: Your eyes told me ...

Vertin: ... you didn't belong to that chess game.

Z: ... You may leave the reports. I need some time.

Vertin: No matter what your decision is ... thank you.

In the middle of the office stands solely the lady in white.

She flips through the files, sighs, and then picks up the phone.

Z: Please put me through Delegate Mark.

The long hallway is located between the Committee and the House of Integratus, forming a bridge between the two loci of power.

Familiar and unfamiliar ones bustle around in the hallway, holding proposals that only have a one-in-ten chance of passing.

Medical Staff I: Hey, Vertin!

Vertin: Hello.

Medical Staff I: Your friend is waiting for you in the rehab center. Mesmer Jr., remember?

Medical Staff II: Let us take you there, so you guys can catch up.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Wet Letter

小径

Wet Letter

> Dear Z, the last person from who I'd expect a letter,
>
> I am glad to hear from you.
> About what you wrote to ask, I didn't find anything. No one in the France branch knows about the "Storm," including the leader and some of the senior officers. I think you have to give up on this one.
> But we need to know more about the "Storm," so do those big shots. That's why the Foundation is desperate for a source of information and values the "Timekeeper" so much. That being the case, we are back to the beginning ... How ridiculous. I don't think there is anything else I can do for you or her.
> The good news is, my business trip to the France branch has been smooth, and I'm estimated to be back in the headquarters tomorrow afternoon (I'm writing this before my way back so I can use the beautiful special stamp I got here).
> Maybe we can have another game by then. The people here are not good at ping-pong, so things became boring after I had beaten everyone I saw.
>
> By the way, congratulations on your promotion.
> I'm glad to know you have already adapted to the style of communication and the work in the Foundation. Clever as you are, we all know you were still thinking and acting the "scientist" way. Anyway, the time no longer goes forward, but it didn't stop. It has brought us to this mess and we have to do something.
>
> One more thing—
> keep the black umbrella you mentioned. You don't always get to find a rain gear used by someone that witnesses and braves the "Storm."
>
> Yours,
> Katz
> From the France branch

The Outsider

4TH-02

The Outsider

Foundation Staff: Ms. Druvis, we are waiting for your response.

Druvis Ⅲ: Now ... I am the last to be invited.

Foundation Staff: Is there anything else that concerns you, Ms. Druvis?

Druvis Ⅲ: When will my friends come back?

Foundation Staff: They are waiting for you outside the suitcase, just as we are. All we want is an opportunity to talk to you face to face.

Druvis Ⅲ: ...

Druvis Ⅲ: Please wait a moment.

There is no time to feel attached to the past.

She looks at the brown granules in her palm. These are seeds of trees.

As she wags the fingers, the seeds are sprinkled on the ground by the stairs. They quickly roll and disappear in the gaps and crevices.

SPDM Library

Her friends are not here, of course.

Druvis Ⅲ: May I ask ... where we are?

Constantine: The library, a place where people let down their guards.

Constantine: Trust always facilitates cooperation, don't you think?

Druvis Ⅲ: ... But I don't even know your name.

Constantine: The name is Constantine. I'm the vice president of the Joint Committee of the Foundation.

Constantine: Please allow me to extend a welcome on behalf of the Foundation.

She taps her pen on the table and calls out a thin pile of documents. The signatures are left blank on the paper.

Constantine: We have sent this document into that suitcase days ago. I should assume that you have read it.

Constantine: What's your conclusion then, Ms. Weyerhaeuser?

Druvis Ⅲ: Are you referring to ... inviting Sotheby, Mr. APPLe and me to join the Foundation?

Druvis Ⅲ: We need to discuss this with Vertin before we give you a proper response.

Druvis Ⅲ: We don't know much about the Foundation. As far as I'm concerned ... I do not yet intend to join any organization.

Constantine: That is to say, you are inclined to turn down my proposal.

Druvis Ⅲ: ...

Druvis Ⅲ: My apologies ... Vertin has not only been of great help to us, but also saved us from the "Storm."

Druvis Ⅲ: I cannot accept the invitation without her opinion, neither can I make decisions for others.

Constantine: Fair enough.

Constantine gets up on her feet and walks to the other side of the table.

There stands an unfinished card tower.

Constantine: You, who accidentally and rather luckily escaped from the "Storm" in 1929 and now seek refuge from the Foundation—Weyerhaeuser, Sotheby, and APPLe. You are the spire of the tower.

Constantine: Between you and the Foundation, the storeys in the middle, are our investigators who go out to rescue the wandering arcanists and humans.

Constantine: Vertin, is one of them.

Constantine: Merely a drop in the ocean.

Druvis Ⅲ: ...!

Constantine: Vertin indeed is the key to connect you and the Foundation.

Constantine: But let's not forget, only an entity as massive and powerful as the Foundation can provide you with long-lasting protection.

Constantine: Without the Foundation's supplies, manpower, and technology, even Vertin can barely sail against the great tides of history, let alone the ordinary people, whose fate is doomed to struggle in the endless hazards of time.

Constantine: Open your eyes and take a look ...

Constantine: We, are the unshakable fortress you should rely on.

Constantine: Do you still wish to talk to Vertin first?

Druvis Ⅲ: ...

Constantine: She is receiving a treatment from us.

Constantine: Which means she won't make it back by your side before any decision is made.

Druvis Ⅲ: ...

Constantine: Her suitcase will also be retrieved for research purposes after the meeting. As compensation for your displacement, we will arrange you a **more decent** room.

Constantine: Ms. Z will show you around the headquarters tomorrow.

Constantine: Go walk around and meet some people ... Perhaps it will help you see what the most beneficial choice to all of us will be.

Constantine: I will wait for your answer.

Constantine: But ...

Constantine: Don't keep me waiting for too long.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Coat Rack

4TH-03

A Coat Rack

Lobby, St. Foundation

Z: ... Yes. I've received the report on the Chicago office.

Z: Well done.

The envelope leaves her and flies out of the window. Madam Z quickly walks through the crowds and stops at a door in a hallway.

Aside from the vibrant secretary area, the entire hallway is bathed in a serene vibe.

This is the door to her own office.

Joint Committee of SF

Constantine: Good timing.

Z: ...!

Constantine: Did I startle you? Considering what we have been through together, I didn't expect you to be as surprised as Ms. Weyerhaeuser was.

Z: ... Sharon didn't tell me you're here.

Constantine: There's no need to tense up. I told her not to say anything.

Constantine: I have talked to Ms. Weyerhaeuser. Everything is going well.

Constantine: She has gotten quite a shock. That little pale face ... like a stressed cat. She is in dire need of comfort from a friend.

Z: What do you want me to do?

Constantine: To do what a good tamer would do. Reach her with a sincere, friendly gesture, ease their pains, answer their questions, and lead them onto the right path.

Constantine: Of course, most importantly, make them be of use to us—to serve the course of the peace of mankind.

Z: I see.

Constantine feels pleased with the response. She gets up and walks towards the door.

Constantine: None of them has signed the agreement.

Constantine: But this recruitment is essential for us. For the short term and for the long run.

Constantine: Can you see what I am doing?

Madam Z listens with her head bowed.

Constantine smiles.

Constantine: Oh, and there's one more thing.

Constantine: Don't address her as "Ms. Weyerhaeuser." She doesn't like it.

Z: I'll take note on that.

She stares at her, until that slim, tall figure goes through the door and disappears in a distant light.

Sotheby: Five and two-thirds portions of silver wine, twenty drops of toad oil, and some crumbles of pure gold from Ucayali ...

Guest Room, St. Foundation

Sotheby rests her head on the table, stirring the semi-solid liquid in the tube.

She contemplates for a bit and takes out two more tubes with bright-colored materials inside from under her dress.

Sotheby: Da da la la la ♪

Sotheby: Last ingredient, the burning acid salts ...

Sotheby: Sotheby's incredible shapeshifting potion will be done at any minute!

The burning acid salts fall into the bowl, and out of that bowl raises a strange smell.

Sotheby: Hmm? Wh-what is going on?! The edge of the potion has turned pink ...

Sotheby: Blimey ... It's the iron bowl ... It reacted with the potion!

Sotheby: Oh no ... This is not good. What effect will it cause now? I should have brought my crucible with me. Nothing can work as a decent vessel here!

She jumps up with annoyance and starts taking circles in the room.

Sotheby: Time is against me. Dinner will be served at any minute. I have to make up my mind now!

She is quickly counting the ingredients hidden under her dress, 23, 24 ... 106 ...

Not far away from the room, footsteps come closer and closer to her closed door.

Guard I: Ms. Sotheby, dinner is ready.

Sotheby: ...!

Sotheby: W-wait! Don't come in!

Sotheby: Ugh, I don't have enough ingredients for another potion! What can I do?

Sotheby: This could be the last chance to make it out ...!

Guard I: Ms. Sotheby? Do you need help?

Sotheby: I-I am putting on stockings! This is lady's dressing time, so don't you come in! Just a minute!

The tube is radiating heat in her palm.

Sotheby: It's alright, I'll be fine. I may look a bit different from expected, but it doesn't matter.

Sotheby: Three, two, one!

She inhales deeply, and finishes the potion in one gulp.

The unperfect potion flows through her throat, reeking of the smell of timber in her esophagus.

She feels something is tickling her in the hair, and her head seems to lose its weight; her nails become fluffy like cotton, stretching out in all directions.

There seems to be a sun hatching in her larynx, hanging over the rest of her body. This is a feeling too distinct to be overlooked.

Sotheby: Ugh ... *coughing* My throat is burning ...

Sotheby: But I made it, didn't I? *coughing* Let me see ... What am I now ...

Sotheby: ... A coat rack?!

Sotheby: Impossible! I was expecting a movable tennis ball!

Guard I: Ms. Sotheby.

Guard I: Please excuse me, but I have to open the door.

Sotheby: ...!

Creak ... *door opens*

Guard I: Ms. Sotheby?

The guard freezes with a dinner plate, looking up and down in bewilderment.

There is truly no one in the room. Nor any places for anyone to hide.

Guard I: ...?

Sotheby: ...

Guard I: This coat rack ... Was it here before?

He doesn't like the way it stands there. He turns his face around to the desk.

He certainly can't miss that muddy semi-finished potion in the bowl.

He cautiously dips his gloved fingers in that suspicious mud and takes a whiff.

Guard I: She must still be in the room.

Yes, indeed. Suffering she is, in this very room.

Sotheby: ...

Itchy. Incredibly itchy.

Her throat feels as if it'd become a lump of soil, where water weeds grow vigorously, and they are dancing, and burning.

Sotheby: ...

Sotheby: *Coughing* ...

Sotheby: *Coughing* ...! Oops ... *Coughing harder* ...

Guard I: ...?! Ms. Sotheby!

Sotheby: Whoa ...!

Sotheby: Jump, jump! Oomph! Oomph! Oomph!

She grips her hat, jumping like a standing twig towards the open door.

What a strenuous move, what a painful pace ... she can't help missing the days when she could walk with two legs.

... But the guard seizes her by the pole.

Guard I: Ms. Sotheby, you are not allowed to leave the room without permission.

Guard I: Please forgive me for being violent.

Sotheby: Ugh ... It's the iron bowl's fault ...

Sotheby: This is false imprisonment! I must get out of here today!!

Sotheby: Bodyguards! Bodyguards!!

Guard I: A-achoo ...!

The potion Sotheby smashes on the floor has taken effect; the guard is deeply troubled by the sneezes one after another.

Sotheby: Hmph! You can never seize Ms. Sotheby the great potion alchemist that easily!

More of the people in white are attracted by the noises in this room.

Guard I: What? What's going on?

Guard I: What's wrong, Ms. Sotheby? Your dress is a mess! Ugh, this room smells terrible ...

Sotheby: Oh! My body is back. The potion's effect ... wears off ...

The guard covered in odd slime tries to get up off the floor with great effort.

Guard I: Achoo! Ugh ... It's good to see you here. W-we must apply for more guards for this room!

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Sun Will Continue to Rise

小径

You fall back into the crowd. I understand. I can feel the desire and depression burning deep inside your brain: you are longing to be a part of an absurd, broken, bizarre arcanum story which is beyond your imagination and past experience.

But sorry, I can't help laughing: you got into some trouble and have to run around blindly among those in white robes like a panicked ant.

Come on. Close your eyes. Imagine inside a TV with static noise, a red-nosed bad guy opens his arms to you and says, "Welcome, to, the, human, world."

Choices

1. These stupid commas!

2. I'm already in the human world.

Branch 1

> I know, dude! As puzzling as our usual big shots. They stand on the podium, with a mic in their hands, and everyone can see their uvula trembling from their wide-open mouths as they speak.
>
> Hello, hello, testing, testing. Three, two, one, three, two, one. Comma, comma, comma. Everyone has to wait for what will happen with a full bladder and an empty stomach.

Branch 2

> Nice pun! But you don't understand what I'm saying, for now. When the day comes, you will find yourself, you will find me, you will find them ... Oh, thinking of that day, my damned heart is beating crazily like a dying reindeer's!
>
> But look at this moment, it's just fine. You know where you should be, and you don't have anything that you shouldn't have in your mind. You just crouch here with patience ...
>
> Listen, this is not just a world of arcanists. Arcanists, arcanum creatures, and even arcanum itself are but insignificant existence hidden beneath all else.
>
> You must learn about those who are in power at the present moment. They live on the other side of the earth, setting rules on the thrones in the scarcely populated wilderness.
>
> Much has been done for the order, for the vision, for the ultimate goal which will satisfy the majority yet sacrifice the minority. They wage wars and strike deals, building a pyramid that symbolizes supreme power with skeletons of the commoners.
>
> No, I'm not telling a lame villain story. On the contrary, it's a boring documentary about those in power standing between the sky and the earth, seeking the real meaning of fairness and ideals.
>
> There's still plenty of time! Go ahead. Keep moving, but don't jump to any conclusion. Just make sure you're always on the way, so you will learn more about humans, more and more.
>
> Take the microscope with you and dig into the rotten history of those poor little things!

Shared continuation

The Sun Will Continue to Rise

Raise A Glass!

4TH-04

Raise A Glass!

Laplace Rehabilitation Center

Brisk, lively running footsteps echo between the walls of the empty hallway.

Leilani: Ms. Lilya! You are here! Here you are! Heh heh ...

Leilani: Our teacher asked me to give you this and asked you to help us to ... um, what was it?

Leilani suddenly stops herself. She scratches her head bewilderedly.

Lilya: To evaluate the mock exam of Zeno's enrollment procedure.

Leilani: Oh right! That's it! I couldn't find you anywhere. They said you are in the rehab center so I came here ... *pants* as quickly as possible ...

Leilani: Well, turns out the moment I saw you, the thing just slipped my mind ... Heh heh, I'm overexcited.

Lilya: Alright, I got it.

Leilani: I'll head back then! It's a great pleasure to see you today!

Leilani: Ms. Lilya! Whoo-hoo! Go for it! Allez! Ganbatte!

Leilani waves at her, running away delightfully.

Lilya: Why "go for it" me ... Do I look like a new recruit to her?

Lilya: Anyway, let me check ...

Lilya: Elevation: 2500 feet, mountainous terrain, dense forest area, good atmospheric visibility. Enemies: ... groups of ground-based wood critters and airborne Olitiau species 04.

Lilya: If we were to engage the enemy in this dense forest and fight in close range, our mobility will be largely reduced, and we can't "barrel roll" to dodge attacks from the ground. But if we pull up and deal with the air force first ...

Lilya: Hmm ... close enough. Ready to fight.

Lilya signs her name on the paper.

Lilya: That's it? Boring.

Lilya: What kind of new recruits they will let in by giving out such a simple exam ...

She takes a few mouthfuls from the military canteen hanging on her belt.

Z: Are you evaluating the battlefield mock exam for this year? I heard Zeno has updated their question bank.

Madam Z walks up to her from the other end of the hallway. Not far away from her, a dressy stranger follows.

Lilya: Nah, just killing time.

She throws the exam paper aside, looking up and down at the wand-holding newcomer. Their eyes meet.

Lilya: ...

Druvis Ⅲ: ...

Druvis Ⅲ: I smelled bison grass.

Lilya: ...?

Druvis Ⅲ: In your canteen.

Lilya: Ha ... right. Authentic Żubrówka, one of the few pastimes I have here.

Lilya: Wanna have a sip?

Druvis Ⅲ: No, thank you.

Druvis Ⅲ: It smells fresh. Tender. Like thyme and lavender in spring. I believe it is precious.

Lilya: You can smell things.

Lilya: Fresh indeed, made in 1929. I'll say it's already about ... Forget it, I don't do maths.

A sensitive time. Without saying any more words, they all cast their eyes on the closest window.

Behind that window, on the bed, lies a patient, securely packed by magnetic coils, rubber tubes, and a transparent helmet.

Lilya: So ... you are here for Vertin too?

Z: I'm showing her around the Foundation, and decided to drop by the rehab center.

Druvis Ⅲ: ...

Mesmer Jr. sits by the bed. She has noticed the visitors at the window, but she doesn't turn around to them.

Her back stiffens even more. A sign of vigilance.

The ward is also guarded by several staff members of the rehabilitation center. Their state-of-the-art equipment spirals up their uniforms.

Druvis Ⅲ: Does she dream?

Z: Sometimes.

Madam Z stares at the reflection of Druvis's face on the glass.

Z: ... Let me show you somewhere else.

Druvis does not say another word. Silently, she follows Madam Z and moves towards the other side of the hallway.

Neither of them looks back. At one point or another, their figures overlap each other, as if they were the same person.

Lilya turns her eyes back on the inert person in bed.

She jiggles the canteen in her hand. It's still half full.

Lilya: You have a good taste, "bellwether."

Lilya: Never tried the vodka from 1929 before. Good for you to get this in the U.S. when both alcohol and coumarin were banned.

Lilya: The thing you said about "Take care of them for me when necessary" ... I'll consider it.

Lilya: Raise a glass, friend.

Lilya: To your health, your soon "recovery."

Lilya: To our better lives.

Lilya: To this unknown date, to this messed-up time.

Lilya: Cheers!

Joint Committee of SF

Z: You have a basic idea of this place now. I'll walk you to your room.

Z: Is there anything else you want to know?

Druvis Ⅲ: ...

Druvis Ⅲ: What do I have to do so you will release Vertin?

Someone has hit the nail on the head.

Z: ...

Z: It depends on what you hope to achieve.

Druvis Ⅲ: Depends on us ... Is that what you said?

Druvis Ⅲ: Vertin, the person we rely on, is being hypnotized in the rehab center.

Druvis Ⅲ: That suitcase, the world we inhabit, has been taken away for research purposes.

Druvis Ⅲ: It's as if the whole thing was manipulated to leave us high and dry and isolated, so that you would have something on us.

Druvis Ⅲ: We do not have a choice, Madam Z.

Z: However, if we change the condition, that "something" they have can turn the negotiation around and in your favor.

Druvis Ⅲ: I ... I do not understand what you mean.

Z: Before she went to the rehab center, Vertin asked me about which department you would be in.

Z: And we have worked out a feasible proposal.

Druvis Ⅲ: ...!

Z: But a catalyst is what we need at present.

Z: The quiet, mild, and tranquil status quo makes the change seem unnecessary.

Z: A proper gust of wind will vitalize the wave of change, and push it to the cusp of revolution.

Druvis Ⅲ: You mean ...

Druvis Ⅲ: But ... it is risky.

Z: That's true.

Z: I cannot give you any promises.

Z: But a fixed pattern of management will only impede the development of everyone. I hold the same idea as Vertin's in this case.

Z: Or, there is another path in front of you. Sign your name and become an official member of the Foundation.

Z: A path that many arcanists who cannot support themselves yearn for.

Druvis Ⅲ: ...

Druvis Ⅲ: So ... you are not inducing me to join the Foundation?

Z: I'm here to show you around.

Z: My senior asked me to make sure that you had a comforting tour.

Z: I hope this tour is helpful for you.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① A Notebook Left Aside

小径

206th LSCC Seminar - Note

At the meeting this morning, MP Callaghan and his great-grandson Dr. Callaghan Jr. submitted the research report On Zebra Crossing, Lemon, Snow Leopard Pattern, and Transportation and Teleportation Arcanum Rituals in joint names.
In the report, they mentioned an innovational point of view on the relations between zebra crossing and the crisis in human subconsciousness, and that between horse herds and the feeling of levitation. Supported by a considerable amount of experiment data, they were granted series D funding of level 1-11 by the LSCC Funding Channel.
In the same meeting, Tchangues 1-07 Stable Release was displayed,
which were given rounds of applause in the room for 17.8 seconds. There is no doubt that the display has won was a great success.
It was a pair of artificial lower limbs. Its skin and blood vessels crafted through cell reproduction and monkey brain transplantation, and the bones and muscles made with branches, white crystal powder, woolen threads and golden privets from the southeast of France. It is capable of all kinds of movements including walking, running, jumping, and gymnastics moves. It could even spider-walk on the wall for 120.7 seconds.

Just as its inventor Ms. Perotti said, "Centered on the rationality and efficiency, we learn from human civilization when we harness the unstable, everchanging arcanum technology, so we can provide real, stable help for more people." There is no doubt Tchangues is a good example of LSCC's core philosophy. Yes, this is the Laplace Scientific Computing Center.

I think I am going to enjoy working here.

11:21, 09/19, Mesmer Jr.
Laplace Minute Book M - Volume 01 - Page 01

In the Castle

4TH-05

In the Castle

Guest Room, St. Foundation

Guard I: Where on earth do these seeds come from?

Guard I: They are stuck in the crevices. Can't even get them out with the gravity vacuum cleaner. It's like they are rooted, tsk.

Guard II: They weren't here until a few days ago. I heard some of these seeds were also found in the rehab center, but the staff there got rid of them in no time.

Guard I: Bloody hell, looks like we have to dig them out one by one with our fingers. Gotta get it done before the inspector's here.

Sotheby: Seed ... What seed?

Sotheby: Hmm, let me take a look ...

She stands on tiptoe, trying her best to figure out what's happening outside the room through the ground glass.

Sotheby: *sighs* I can't see anything! I'm so bored.

Sotheby: Do I really have to sign the agreement to get out? But I haven't discussed it with anyone yet.

Sotheby: "A fair lady always thinks it through and reaches an agreement with the adults before she signs any document ..."

Sotheby: Mr. Karson has said that hundreds of times. It must be vital!

Sotheby: ... Mmm.

There comes a disturbance from the other side of the door.

Material Room Staff: Backup, we need backup! Emergency!

Material Room Staff: A whole forest appears in room 101, the material area! It's ... It's growing out of Timekeeper's suitcase!

Guard II: What are you talking about?

Material Room Staff: As I said, it's an emergency. The staff in room 102 and 103 are here to help.

Material Room Staff: A large number of branches came out of the suitcase. They can detect our positions and even attack us on their own!

Guard I: Did you use Drako Drought?

Material Room Staff: Of course not! The room is full of inflammables. The whole floor would be burning now if we did.

Material Room Staff: We used military chainsaws, but it's a drop in the bucket ...

Guard I: Fine. I'll go apply for a few more. Just wait for me there.

Guard I: Agata, go help them out!

Guard II: Roger that!

Sotheby: A forest is growing out of Ms. Vertin's suitcase ...

Sotheby: Could it be ... Ms. Druvis's great arcane skill?☆

Sotheby: The guards are gone ... Ugh, I wish I could see that bizarre scene myself.

Click ...

Sotheby: Hmm? What's that strange sound?

She lays her eyes on the shut door.

The keyhole is rattling.

Sotheby: Hmm ... Is the door shaking?

The rattle visibly becomes stronger.

Sotheby: No, something ... something is coming in!

The lock shakes so violently, as if it were wrestling something invisible.

Sotheby: ...!

The newborn vine ruthlessly pierces through the lock, leaving the latter hanging in the air like lifeless grapes.

The air smells like fresh plant juice.

Sotheby: Wow ...

Sotheby: The lock, it's actually broken ...

Sotheby: Which means I'm free to go? Hooray!!

The door quietly opens, giving a way to the outside world.

The place outside has turned into a vigorous new world.

Sotheby: Wow ...! The seeds on the ground have all sprouted ...

Sotheby: What on earth is going on?

She is baffled, as she fiddles with the sprouts on the ground.

Sotheby: Hmm, the seeds have the same color as the crevice's. I would have missed them if I didn't look carefully ...

Sotheby: Such a slender branch actually broke the lock. How marvelous! You are Ms. Sotheby's hero!

Foundation Staff: Hey! How did you get out?!

Sotheby: ...!

She is violently pushed to the ground.

Sotheby: Ugh ... That hurts!

Sotheby: How rude you are! My potions are broken!

Foundation Staff: Did you conjure these plants? Stop them now!

Sotheby: Huh? What are you talking about?

She turns around to surprisedly find that the sprouts, soaked in the potion, are visibly getting thicker and stronger.

Sotheby: Oh my ...

Sotheby: It's my ... Quick Quick Growth Potion for plants!

Twigs thicken into branches, and more new branches come out from them. And new leaves, new sprouts. They crawl forward, forming a tree fortress around Sotheby.

Foundation Staff: What do you think you're doing?! Stop them!

Sotheby: I ...

Sotheby: Hmph, no way!

Sotheby: Come on! Try and catch me again if you can!

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Forest Express

4TH-06

The Forest Express

Guest Room, St. Foundation

X: Alright, here are ... 30 cans of Dr. Papper, 20 bags of Happy Wedges, 11 bags of Big Foot Gummy, and a bottle of insect repellent for plants.

Just as he finishes the sentence, a heavy box falls through the chimney, weightily landing in the fireplace.

X: Oh, good timing.

X: There may be a bit of ash on them, but the flavor and texture should still be fine.

Regulus: Ugh ... *coughs*

Regulus: The ash is killing me. That's way more than a bit ...

X: I can't just carry them with me in broad daylight. Do you know how many procedures I have gone through just to pay you a visit?

X: But how come you are locked in the same room? Since when has the Foundation become so benevolent?

APPLe: They would like Captain to guide me to the right path ... to join the Foundation. After all, Captain was already a member of them.

Regulus: Yep. But I don't feel any difference in the benefits I get! At best, I could contact someone from the outside ... and you're here.

Regulus: So? Texas Hold'em?

X: ...

X: That's not what I'm here for.

X: I've shown you the "Storm" records these years. So did you find anything?

Regulus: Hmm ...

Regulus: You call it a record, but it's so brief that it only has start time and duration ...

Regulus: I can't tell any pattern from that!

APPLe: This APPLe believes that the "Storm," which happens randomly, does not conform to the self-adjusting nature of the universe.

Regulus: Self-adjusting ... Hmm ...

Regulus: Oh!

Regulus: Is that the theory you mentioned before? Something like "there should be someone who intervenes or improves the system in order to reduce the growth of the instability of the universe" ...

Regulus: For example, if the universe is a mooring rope ... no, a bunch of ropes ... there has to be a sailor who pulls the ropes to keep them in order or something.

X: Sounds like the cosmology from centuries ago ...

He doesn't seem keen on the theory, nor does he repel it; he just quickly spins on his heels without saying a word.

X: But your metaphor reminds me of Madam Z's research on string theory.

X: She advocates that the energy string is the most basic unit of the universe.

Regulus: Are you talking about Vertin's boss?

X: Boss?

X: Well, if that's your definition of immediate supervisor, then yes.

X: Madam Z was a scientist who studied in Britain before she joined the Foundation.

Regulus: Ooh. Bread and honey are the staff of life. That makes sense.

X: Well, it's not a good choice for most scientists.

X: Recently she has been promoted from the chief of the vice president's staff to a formal member of the Committee. I guess she will spend even less time in the lab ...

A sudden, violent bump comes from outside the door.

APPLe: Uhhh ...!

APPLe: The whole building shakes. Did something hit it?

X: Let me see.

Looking out of the window, they see a giant oak, cut down from its bottom, leaning on the hallway of the second floor.

Among its ever-growing branches stands a familiar figure in a black dress. A young teenager with a hat, waggling and swaying on a branch, follows her.

Summoned by a peculiar chanting, more and more trees grow up from the ground, stretch, and spread in mid-air.

X: Is that Druvis? And ... Sotheby?

X: ...

He turns around, looking serious.

X: What's this? Guys ...

X: I am not gonna be dragged into a riot at this point.

Regulus: Ah ... Is that Druvis? What happened to her?

Regulus: ... Her new hairstyle is sort of cool.

APPLe: Captain, that's not the point.

X: Agreed, not the point at all. I gotta go. If you want me to take part in such an event, my name should never be in the visitor log.

X: Looks like the whole building will be your battlefield ...

X: Alright, good luck.

Regulus: Wait a minute!

Regulus: If we join Druvis ... what would happen?

X: ...

X: What would happen? I'm not a prophet.

X: But this is gonna be the best spot for protest.

X: This building is the furthest one from the center of the Foundation. On the first and second floors are material rooms and research offices. Few staff stay here.

X: The room next to yours is the projection lab.

X: It was used to control the slides projected in the lobby. That screen is gone now, but the transfer devices and circuits are still there.

X: You know what? If you're going to protest ... make it loud.

X: It's been a long time since the Foundation had something this much fun.

He pulls out the one sleeve in Regulus's grip and quickly exits the room.

Sotheby: Ms. Druvis, is Vertin having a fight with the Foundation?

Druvis Ⅲ: ... Yes.

Druvis Ⅲ: We have a disagreement with the Foundation, Ms. Sotheby.

Druvis Ⅲ: Vertin is seeking a limited freedom for us. Her aspiration is to restore the peaceful life before the "Storm."

Druvis Ⅲ: For the authorities, however, her aspiration and ambition are labeled as deviation and rebellion.

Druvis Ⅲ: We are thus tempted, alienated, and arrested unjustly.

Sotheby: That's why we've been grounded all these days ...

Sotheby: So we're helping Vertin now, is that right, Ms. Druvis?

Sotheby: I really feel like doing something for her ...! Just like what I'm doing right now, standing brave on the tree!

Druvis Ⅲ: Right. On the tree.

Druvis Ⅲ: We need to move forward, to move one step further.

Druvis Ⅲ: When we meet up with Regulus and APPLe, our voices will be stronger, and more and more people will offer their help.

Druvis Ⅲ: I believe that when the day comes, we will be able to shake up the balance in the Foundation and tilt it to our side.

Sotheby: Shake up the balance ... Wow ...

Sotheby: Maybe Vertin will come back herself by then!

Sotheby: I got it! Now my goal is to make more potions, so the trees can grow larger and larger, make them super large!

Druvis Ⅲ: This is going to be a protracted war of resistance.

Druvis Ⅲ: After we rescue Regulus, please maintain our territory of the woods with the rest of your potions, Ms. Sotheby.

Sotheby: Sure! I will economize on them!

Sotheby: Look, X is coming out of the room!

Druvis Ⅲ: He left. It seems he has made his choice.

Sotheby: Not helping us or them ... Well, at least no one is getting hurt from the boiling pot this time.

Sotheby: Let me see. Hmm, there are more guards at the door now! It seems everyone's there!

Druvis Ⅲ: Perhaps they have guessed our next move ... Regulus.

Druvis Ⅲ: Let's go. It's time to meet up with our companions.

Sotheby: Go, go! Regulus must be bored to death just as I was!

Druvis raises her wand.

As the chant goes on, her hair has become increasingly glistening gold.

The oaks march on like waves. Their bud scales keep growing, extending, chasing, and overlapping each other, and their crowns shoot forward like missiles.

Guard II: Watch out! Incoming!

Guard I: Everyone, get ready to engage!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Projector Relay Controller

小径

To Lawrence Cavendish

The Pirate's Declaration

4TH-07

The Pirate's Declaration

Lobby, St. Foundation

The receptionist is confirming the name list just submitted by the House of Integratus.

The vice president is coming her way. It's rare to see her picking up the files herself.

But as the daily agenda tracker shows, the chance of the vice president asking for this name list is 85%.

Constantine: Do we have the candidates' name list? Show it to me.

Clerk: Yes, please wait a minute. It'll be prepared right away.

That's right. Thanks to the invention designed by Laplace Scientific Computing Center, everything here is highly controllable, efficient, and has logic within.

The fingers of the receptionist lightly percuss the keyboard. She will be able to locate the files faster than ever.

Suddenly, she freezes.

Clerk: Um, why is the light on?

With a horrible prediction in her mind, she hesitantly turns to the wall with an open mouth and round eyes.

"Buzzz ..."

A gigantic projection appears on the wall.

An apple shows up in the blurry projection. Under such a poor resolution, it looks like a massive red alert.

A sentence in a crooked font emerges beneath that giant pixel apple .

The words are glaring, "THIS IS WAR!"

Regulus: Warning, warning! Everybody, listen up. We have taken over the Foundation!

Regulus: Our demands are: release us, set Vertin free!

Regulus: You have three days. After that, we are ...

The receptionist cuts off the power, terrified.

The lobby, which sees people striding in and stalking off all the time, now freezes in dead silence.

Clerk: Madam ... I ...

Clerk: I didn't ... I ...

Clerk: ...

Constantine: What's the matter? Something wrong with the printer?

Clerk: No, no ... Oh right, the candidate name list ... Here you are.

She passed on the name list with a pale face.

Constantine: Thank you, this is exactly what I need.

Constantine casts a quick look at the wall.

The source of the disturbance has gone.

Constantine: Sorry for the scene.

Constantine: Like others here, they also have the right to make their voices heard. It is the essential step for us to come to an agreement.

Constantine: We will take care of this, don't worry.

She smiles. As she does so, the people around her are visibly relieved and stored to life.

Constantine: However ... perhaps we should stop using the old projector. It may lead to accidents, don't you think?

Clerk: Understood! I'll remove the transfer devices now ...

She jumps up on her feet and salutes her.

Constantine turns around and leaves.

Regulus: Oh bloody hell! How dare they cut off the power ...

Regulus: This Pirate has so much left to declare!

Regulus: Wimps! Cowards! Hypocrites!

Sotheby: Hear, hear! I can't agree more. It is very rude to hang up before others finish their words!

APPLe: This is not telephone, Ms. Sotheby.

APPLe: But of course, that's not the point.

APPLe: No matter what, we've communicated to them the most crucial requirement for negotiation.

APPLe: I'm sure they will respond to us properly.

Regulus: Humph ... I just wanna take the chance to show our attitude ...

Regulus: Taking over the radio station at the headquarters of the Foundation ... It's a gas in the late hundreds of years ...

Regulus: *sighs* It would've been perfect if we could have another You Can't Win to close it out.

APPLe: We could look around here to see if there's other broadcasting equipment.

APPLe: However, this APPLe does not recommend frequent provocation.

APPLe: Right now it's more important to patrol the surroundings in case we are ambushed by the guards.

APPLe: Ms. Druvis is forming abatis alone downstairs. Perhaps she needs our help.

Regulus: Mmm ... Fine, you have a point.

Regulus: This Pirate ... has decided to put off the plan to liberate the Foundation!

Almost reluctantly, she forces herself to stop looking at the radio.

Regulus: Besides forming abatis, what else do we need to do?

APPLe: There's much to be done, Captain.

APPLe: Find water sources. Transfer essential equipment. Reserve enough food. Set up multiple defenses in the woods.

APPLe: And arrange a duty schedule. Make sure someone is garrisoned outside the suitcase, while others are resting inside.

Sotheby: Well, I have the tomato and potato seeds from Ms. Druvis. We must plant them in the suitcase to guarantee food supply!

Regulus: Um ... Tomato and potato ...

Regulus: All vegetables, no meat ... they're meant for the piggies that grow my bacon.

Regulus: When I was wandering the seas, at least I could have a grilled sea bass every day ...

Regulus: *sighs* I wonder what Vertin eats in rehab ... Will she be hungry ...

"Grrrr ..."

Regulus: Oooh! Almost forgot about the goodies X sent!

Regulus: We'll definitely hang in there for a few more days with them!

Regulus: Sotheby, Mr. APPLe, you go downstairs first. I'll meet up with you once I bring the box down there!

Sotheby: Alright! We will meet you at the entrance. Stay safe!

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① A Rating Sheet Left Behind

小径

Snacks of the New Era and the Rockin' Pirate

○ Rigabit: Yogurt Bullets
Pink yogurt from Michigan which pops out like a bullet.
"Not so good as I thought it would be, but does feel novel ...
Hmm, well, mmm ... 5.6 out of 10."

○ K&K: Oatmeal Breakfast Bars
Actually a candy bar with little oatmeal.
"Not bad, I'll give it an 8."

○ Kjeldson!!! Logger Cookies!!!
Known for the rich butter within, it has a rough flavor of the logger style which is exactly the opposite of the royal style.
"What does logger style mean, dry as sawdust?!
I will put in on the Prohibited List of my ship and it's never getting removed! 1 out of 10!"

○Pota-ta-tato: Face Chips
There are all kinds of facial expressions. I may look the same when deep fried.
"Too many crumbs. Can't taste the flavor of potato. BARBECUE WITH MUSTARD FLAVORED ...
Well, acceptable. 4.5 out of 10."

○ Cheetahs Cheetahs! Amazing Seeds!
Puffed snack. CHEESE SURINAME TOAD JAM FLAVORED.
"When your product is buried in soil but can't grow into anything after 3 days of watering, 24 times in total by the way, you'd better not put the word 'Seed' in its name! 0!
CHECK, OUT, THIS, BIG, ZERO!"

Both Sides of the Table

4TH-08

Both Sides of the Table

The meeting room

Committee Member I: There is no need to hold an emergency meeting for this.

Committee Member I: Such "declaration of war" without tactic or plan B is typical example of arcanist behavior.

Committee Member I: The area they controlled has no value at all, no matter in terms of the size or the influence.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Well, the administration department has not taken official actions yet.

Committee Member Ⅱ: I heard the plan was to dispatch a team to escort them to the School of Discipline.

Committee Member I: Problem solved then.

The books of case files are closed. As the chairs squeakily scratch the floor, the attendants of the meeting stand up.

Z: Next time, if Vertin brings back more unregistered arcanists ...

Z: Will the same thing happen again?

Madam Z stands still where she was.

The committee member stops by the door, and slowly turns back to her.

Committee Member I: I don't understand.

Committee Member I: It's not a shame to join the Foundation, is it?

Committee Member I: By signing the agreement, arcanists will enjoy the right to use arcane skills in human society and be bestowed great honor.

Committee Member I: The human resource department could have used a whole floor to hold the applications a dozen years ago!

Committee Member I: Not even the New Age Movement could challenge the Foundation's authority in the international community!

Committee Member I: And these shortsighted exceptions ... They aren't even worth being made a topic for the meeting.

Z: Yet ...

Z: They're not here for the St. Pavlov Foundation.

Z: They're here for Vertin. They choose to follow her out of their own will, because of their admiration for her.

Z: That is the essential difference between them and our former recruits.

Committee Member II: You mean ... it's not important at all for them to join the Foundation.

Z: I'm afraid so.

Z: But we can't expel them.

Z: We both know that the Foundation now requires new members to form a stronger force.

Committee Member I: What are you trying to say, Ms. Z? Skip to the point.

She returns to her seat, sits down, and opens the folder again.

Z: Today, the House of Integratus has resubmitted the revised draft of *Storm Reformation: Manpower and Discipline*.

Z: I think it's time to decide if this draft can be adopted and then start the debate.

Committee Member II: You're asking for troubles, madam ...

Z: Please turn to page 21, section 3.

Z: "External personnel recruited by the Timekeeper should be placed within the Timekeeper's department."

Z: "The Timekeeper has the duties of education and discipline to them and should be responsible for their follow-up behaviors."

Z: "Personnel within the Timekeeper's department, subject to the Foundation's Staff Code, will take orders from the Timekeeper and are not required to take direct orders from the Foundation."

Z: This section allows those unregistered arcanists to have more autonomy and develop a stronger sense of identity as a part of the Foundation.

Z: Meanwhile, by giving orders to the Timekeeper, the Foundation still has the military right to deploy them.

Z: It can solve the current problem.

Committee Member I: Which means we'll be working with some uncontrollable mercenaries.

Z: I'll say it's the reserve service for wartime.

Committee Member I: It's not going to work. What happened when the arcanists were not under control?

Committee Member I: Massacres, tyranny, endless revenge ... History is nothing but a sewer to them, where they vent their excessive energy and deceive those in power with a speech of ignorance.

Committee Member I: The reality has proven that.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Exactly. What's more, there has never been a reform as such in the history of the Foundation.

Committee Member Ⅱ: During the unexpected "Storm," reforming in a rush will only increase the ri- ...

Constantine: Sorry for being late.

Constantine strides into the meeting room, throwing her folder on the table.

Constantine: Quite a heated discussion.

Constantine: I can see you all have a great interest in this draft proposal.

Constantine: Hope I didn't miss too much.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① A Determined Visitor

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

A Ride on the Toboggan

小径

Sounds of different colors go into your left ear and slip out from your nostrils, just like a toboggan sliding down a soft piste from a cabin up the mountain to the finishing line at the foot, leaving nothing but excitement that doesn't even last.

Choices

1. Your opening line sucks.

2. So, a vacation? I'm ready.

Branch 1

Errr ...

What did you say? I, I got bad signal here, oh, ba-bad signal indeed.

I mean, I may be different from all of you, but I have a conscience, OK? I never talk s**t, that's the bottom line. What I said were all felicitous hints.

Branch 2

Yes. You're always so clever, with an excellent sense of humor! Now take all the cold-proof equipment you've got. The view is good here, but it's still dangerous as you are climbing a snow mountain after all.

I'm sure you have noticed it. Between the glacier and the valley, between the snow mountain and the lake, stands a great building we're all familiar with.

Close your eyes and feel the patterns of interlaced gray and white. The flow of the building, so balanced and symmetrical, is like a sophisticated symphony with beautiful melody.

That may be your first impression of the Foundation. After that committee meeting, however, all I could see on your face was a terrible mess, like it was licked by a terrier which has just finished hunting.

What the f**k are they talking about? Who can explain their relations for me?

Good question! In this lonely, whirling, dark universe, I'm the only one who is willing to tell you all these stories on the cold bench in the park.

Choices

1. So what functions does the Foundation have?

2. Who is the boss of the Foundation?

Branch 2.1

Countless! Oh man, you gotta understand, an international political institution with great ambition is bound to make troubles and make up for them.

The House of Integratus and the committee are in charge of lawmaking, not just in the Foundation, but in countries and even in the global society! Any affairs related to the human-arcanist relationship will be brought to their table, and they will handle each of the affairs with their properly manicured but muscle-torn hands.

Through the folds in their brains, people set this reasonable rule: delegates of the House of the Integratus are elected to take responsibility for their constituencies. As busy as bees, they submit countless proposals to the committee every year.

Then the committee will choose one lucky proposal and send it to the next step: all the committee members would gather to debate and vote for the proposal, like what happened in a Medieval Fair.

Many would show up in the fair. There would be political parties, a moderator, dozens of expert groups, each with a different standpoint and goal. It's like a mental boxing, modern version! We will have to wait while listening to the war of words. After dozens of days, or even months, we will finally get to see who wins the championship belt.

Branch 2.2

You haven't met him yet. Actually, only a few have, as the opportunities are always fleeting like the falling stars.

But it's okay. The Foundation still works well without him! Our responsible Constantine, working without any complaint like an unbreakable lily, is trying hard to change the Foundation's direction to what she believes to be correct.

Come on, let's look at the bigger picture. Humans have worked out with the brilliant folds in their brains that they need multiple parties to create a balance of power. So, bang! There come the committee, the House of the Integratus, and many other administration departments.

The House of Integratus and the committee are in charge of lawmaking, not just in the Foundation, but in countries and even in the global society! Any affairs related to the human-arcanist relationship will be brought to their table, and they will handle each of the affairs with their properly manicured but muscle-torn hands.

The committee has the right to approve or reject the proposals from delegates. Well, of course, some of the delegates are very stubborn. They will keep submitting their proposals no matter how many times they have been rejected, just like a red-back shrike with fledglings repeatedly submitting rejected motions until they are exhausted.

When it comes to the formal debate, you will get to watch a dogfight full of polite yet viciously aggressive language. Everyone, including the president, the delegates, the parties and the expert groups, will turn into maniacs in the arena of power.

After this stage, the final result depends on the white marble house. They seldom express their opinions, but they will sometimes.

Choices

1. Are there more?

Oh, yes, yes. Look how polite you are when you ask that question, like I'm some high school student working part-time in a mall selling local socks to you.

And I'd be very nice and tell you, "Of course!" We must not ignore the other administration departments of the Foundation, as well as the headquarters' poor branches located in different countries and the humanitarian School of Primary Defense of Mankind that works like a poorhouse.

Remember, the Foundation is managing the whole world! Of course, they need some rules that are hard to understand, so the wise will be wiser and the silly will be sillier, while those in the middle will show an innocent smile when they die!

Humans are experts on these things. My stupid arcanists, don't just complain; learn to see what they are after, okay? Catch the unspoken drifts between the lines! So one day you will understand ...

Life is like a ride on the toboggan.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

A Ride on the Toboggan

A Wandering Dog

4TH-09

A Wandering Dog

Committee Member I: We are on page 21, section 3.

Committee Member I: Ms. Z insists on adopting this draft.

Committee Member I: Ms. Z, please walk Madam Constantine through this section.

Constantine: No need for that. I have read the stenographer's report.

Constantine: In fact, this is the second time I'm addressing this proposal. Considering the Integratus has been very determined to its submission, I believe many delegates must have a burning interest in the case.

Constantine: At least it's worth some discussions.

Constantine: Pedra, why do you oppose it?

Committee Member I: The rise of Manus Vindictae has caused the arcanum world to gradually break free from the Foundation.

Committee Member I: Therefore we need to monitor what our arcanists think and control what they do in a stricter manner, in case they go too far.

Committee Member I: Manus Vindictae has a subversive slogan. Their influence has been getting bigger since the first "Storm," so has the scale of their infiltration.

Committee Member I: In The Walden incident in 1929, we were given away in advance. It probably had something to do with the infiltration.

Constantine: Very well, a point worth discussion.

Constantine: But it is not relevant to our subject here and now.

Constantine: Stenographer, please take down the point Mr. Rosa just made. That will be the subject of our meeting in the third week.

Constantine: Katz, what do you think?

Committee Member II: The expectations of our constituencies are on our shoulders.

Committee Member II: Fear of the arcanists has grown due to the attacks by Manus Vindictae in many regions.

Committee Member II: It's not ideal for us to implement the "Peace Policy" and promote the arcane technology.

Committee Member II: To maintain the Foundation's reputation, we have to start with the registered arcanists. Strengthen the regulations, and show the public that arcanists are reasonable and trustworthy.

Committee Member II: That is why I am opposed to the draft.

Constantine: ... Inspiring.

She stands up, pacing around in the meeting room.

Constantine: However, what a shame, none of you have realized the key factor in this subject.

Constantine: What is the key element that decides whether this proposal will be approved or not?

Constantine: Manus Vindictae?

Constantine: The constituents?

Constantine: No. It's far simpler than those.

Constantine: It's Vertin.

Z: ...

Constantine: According to the proposal, Vertin will become the only tie between these unregistered arcanists and the Foundation.

Constantine: As the number of Vertin's field missions increases, she will inevitably get in touch with more and more unregistered arcanists.

Constantine: That is to say, outside the Foundation's jurisdiction, a group of people is getting stronger each day—an armed force.

Constantine: Her attitude towards the Foundation will be the key to all the issues.

Z: Vertin received her education in SPDM from an early age. She has a clear tendency.

Constantine: Yes, that's what I think.

Constantine: That's also why I have asked someone who can provide a valid argument on the issue to join us.

Constantine: You may come in, Sonetto.

Z: ...!

The door is pushed ajar.

Sonetto enters the room, humbly and prudently. Her uniform seems to have changed a little.

Sonetto: ... Good day, Madam Vice President. Greetings to all committee members. May the peace be with us.

Constantine: The Timekeeper is still in treatment. Before she is restored to health, I appoint you to take care of all the relevant matters on her behalf.

Sonetto: Copy that.

Constantine: Now, I will ask you some questions. Please answer them truthfully.

Sonetto: Clear.

Constantine: Based on your observation, do you or do you not think the Timekeeper has been loyal to the Foundation?

Sonetto: ...!

Sonetto: Of, of course!

Sonetto: All the students of the School of Primary Defense of Mankind are devoted to the peace of mankind. We have pledged lifelong allegiance to the Foundation that leads the cause.

Constantine: Heh heh, that's not what I'm asking.

Constantine: Let's put it differently. Why do you think Vertin would provoke other students to rebel when she was in school?

Sonetto: I ... I do not know ...

Sonetto: I am sorry.

Constantine: After the incident of the "Storm," why would Vertin show reluctance to invite the unregistered arcanists to join the Foundation?

Sonetto: Because ... Emm ...

Constantine: At one point in her negotiation with the Manus Vindictae, Vertin has agreed to join them. What do you think her true intention was?

Sonetto: I ...

Constantine: That'll be enough. I believe we all have our answers by now.

Sonetto: Madam Vice President! A-According to our investigation of the event in 1929 and Timekeeper's report, it is highly possible that Arcana of Manus Vindictae has the arcane power to influence the sanity and consciousness of others from a certain distance.

Sonetto: She is able to exert an irresistible psychic influence on others through short conversations. Timekeeper ... Timekeeper was under huge threats at that time.

Sonetto: I think all of her responses were out of her survival instinct.

Sonetto: This is also one of the survival strategies that have been taught in Chapter 1, Book 3 of *Introduction to Strategy* edited by the School of Primary Defense of Mankind.

Constantine: I see. You may leave the room now.

Sonetto's eyes turn red.

Sonetto: I ...

Constantine: We appreciate the information you just added. You have always been an excellent student. We are very proud of you.

Constantine: Now it's time to leave and rest.

Sonetto: ... Copy that.

She leaves the room as instructed.

Committee Member I: ...

Committee Member II: ...

Z: ...

Silence fills the room.

Constantine: What a controversial issue.

Constantine: What's your view on this, Ms. Z?

Madam Z stands up. She takes her time before speaking.

Z: In my point of view ... Vertin does have doubts about current system.

Z: But doubts don't mean disloyalty.

Z: In fact, if we want to further expand the staff to contend against the Manus Vindictae...

Z: We need flexible management.

Z: Apply customized standards to arcanists with different backgrounds and different training objectives.

Z: Through this, not only can we remove the doubts of Vertin, but also ease the tension between the Foundation and other unregistered arcanists.

Constantine squints at her.

Constantine: You have been very thoughtful.

Constantine: Carry it out then.

The stenographer pauses out of surprise.

She looks up at Constantine, seeking confirmation from the look on her face.

The stenographer quickly regains her composure and starts typing.

"Pass"

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① A Troublesome Neighbor
小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Sailing at Night
4TH-10

Sailing at Night

Guest Room, St. Foundation

Matilda: Silver divination stand, white silk, pearls soaked in night dew ...

Matilda: Hmm, what else lunar materials do I need ...

Matilda: Alright! Let me see how much frankincense and myrrh are left ...

Matilda: Cool, just the quantity I need.

Matilda immerses herself in the work on the desk. She checked the installment of the curtains repeatedly, making sure the moonlight will precisely shed on the orb.

A low noise is growing in a vessel not far away from her.

But she has no clue at all.

Matilda: Okay, all set. Incense basin, my incense basin ...

She turns around.

Matilda: Ahhh!

The incense basin falls, making a hollow sound on the Soumak.

???: ~♪

A pair of pointy ears emerge from behind the basin.

Matilda: You again! Annoying divination sprites!

Matilda: You are not stealing anything from me this time!

???: ~♪~♪

Her attitude doesn't bother these transparent creatures at the moment.

Unlike any ordinary critters who always act in a group, only one or two of them are more than enough to get people in trouble.

Their thin, slim hands grab hold of the edge of the silver incense basin. They are flying towards the window.

Matilda: Hey! Where are you taking my basin?! Stop it!

She jumps up the windowsill and grips the other edge of the basin.

Matilda: Ugh ... Looks like you need a good lesson to understand why you shouldn't do this!

Matilda: Wait and see. I'll let you know the consequence of messing with Ms. Matilda Bouanich!

The silver basin falls to the floor, knocking a shallow crater on it.

Divination Sprite: × ... ×!

The sprites are crawling under the window, looking flabby and weak. Apparently, they have taken quite a shock.

Matilda picks up the basin and wipes out the dust.

Matilda: Ha, he who laughs last, laughs best! It's me, ME!

Divination Sprite: ♮♭♮♯♭♯♮♯♭!

They burst out an incomprehensible curse, sneaking away from the window with drooping wings on their backs.

Matilda: Ugh ... these troublemakers. I'm exhausted.

Matilda: It's kinda late ... Oh! Thank goodness, I didn't miss the high tide!

Hurriedly, she starts to restore the order on the desk.

Matilda: Set the props ...

Matilda: I can't be distracted again. Divination takes my full attention and energy ...

However, there's a knock on the door.

Matilda: ...

Matilda: Ahem! The high tide caused by the moon is coming. Let me see, estimated to start at 20:45.

Matilda: Three minutes to go.

Matilda: Gotta purify the orb when the high tide starts to make sure the divination is correct ...

The knock comes again.

Matilda frowns.

Matilda: Calm down, calm down. This is the key moment ... Whoever it is, I must not be distracted!

Matilda: Alright ... Focus, focus.

Matilda: Eyes closed ... Focus ... Imagine my body rising and falling alongside the tide under the blessing of the moon ...

Matilda: And she is on the other side of the sea ... waiting for me to find her ...

Matilda: Time to burn the incense ...

Matilda: Show yourself in the orb, Sonett- ...

Sonetto: Matilda, are you there?

Matilda: ...?!

Matilda: Wh-what is ... going on?

Sonetto: I am sorry, but I think I heard your voice.

Sonetto: I need to ask you ... a favor.

Her voice sounds different. Exhausted, almost rusty, as if it were coming out from an old cassette.

Matilda: C-coming! Um, w-wait a minute!

Matilda: I'm, uh, busy! W-Wait there and be patient!

In a great panic, she pulls up the silk, covers the orb, and sticks the both of them into a corner of the couch.

The door opens.

They both stand inside the door frame, toe to toe, blocking each other's way. As they awkwardly try to move, they go up and retreat in the same direction, as if this were a tango tutorial.

Matilda eventually steps back and lets Sonetto in.

Matilda: Now tell me your request! Wh-what brings you to the bright and intelligent Ms. Bouanich at this time?!

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto forces a smile on her face.

Sonetto: Could you please read the future for me?

Matilda sees something she has never seen before on Sonetto's face.

They sit down by the orb.

Myrrh is quietly burning next to them.

Matilda: Alright. Now is a good time to ask the moon for help ...

Matilda: Clean your hands in the silver pot, and put them on mine.

Matilda: Okay. Now sit opposite me, and gaze into the orb.

Sonetto: Okay.

She does what she is told. She sees nothing but a clear whiteness in the orb.

Matilda: Are you here to confess, to interpret a dream, or to seek the prophecy of the crystal?

Sonetto: I am here to confess ... and to seek the prophecy.

Matilda: Tell me about the vision in your heart.

Sonetto: The vision ...?

Sonetto: Hmm ...

She looks at the orb. The shape of the sphere becomes blurry and gradually fades out in her sight.

Sonetto: I ...

Sonetto: See myself falling ...

Sonetto: There are two broken decks ... They were originally one piece.

Sonetto: Every time I get closer to one deck, the other one sinks.

Sonetto: People on it will fall with it.

Sonetto: I can feel the coldness of the deep water, and the pains when they struggle.

Matilda: Are you sad about it?

Sonetto: ... I ...

Sonetto: I feel fear.

Sonetto: ...

Matilda: I see ... Which deck would you like to approach intuitively? Can you recognize the people on them?

Sonetto: I ...

Sonetto: There is something bright on that deck, just like ... Timekeeper and Druvis ... It is warm there.

Matilda: ... You are attracted to it subconsciously. It guides the way of your heart.

Matilda: What about the other?

Sonetto: The other deck ... makes me feel comfortable, as if I have spent a long time there.

Sonetto: I can trace back every step I take.

Matilda: Perhaps that symbolizes your senses.

Matilda: Sonetto, are you having trouble making a choice?

Matilda: I can see the conflict ... between your instinct and senses.

Sonetto: ...

Matilda: I heard you attended the committee's meeting today.

Matilda: Anything happened?

Sonetto: I said something wrong.

Sonetto: I was not properly prepared ...

Sonetto: I was unable to help Timekeeper and Druvis; instead, I created a deeper misunderstanding.

Sonetto: What choice should I make ... to resolve their conflict? Stalemate like that ... really scares me.

Matilda: ...

Matilda can't find a word.

She sits there frozen, covering Sonetto's wrist with her palms.

Matilda: The bright deck ... seems closer and larger.

Matilda: Have you ever thought about following your heart?

Sonetto: ...

Matilda: Sonetto, maybe you can try following your instinct for once.

Matilda: Maybe something unexpected will happen.

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: I tried.

Sonetto: ... Four years ago.

Sonetto: I let them go ... That was the worst decision I have ever made.

Matilda: ...!

Sonetto's hands are on the orb again.

Sonetto: I am ready. Please tell me the right choice.

Matilda: ... Okay.

As the chaotic snowflakes disappear, the shape of the orb is becoming blurry again.

Crystals emerge in thin air ...

... One after another, they build up a symmetrical and balanced ship.

Everything has its trace to follow, its logic to function.

Matilda: "The reality has shown itself."

Matilda: "Take the path you have already taken, walk the way you have already walked."

Matilda: "You shall benefit from listening to the voice in your mind, as it is not yet time to dock."

Sonetto: Listen to the voice in my mind ...

Sonetto: I see.

Sonetto: I should not have hesitated.

Sonetto: Thank you, Matilda. Your divination is very helpful ... My mind is very clear now.

Matilda: You're ... Ha, of course you should thank me!

Matilda: You should have known the resourcefulness of Ms. Matilda Bouanich much earlier.

Matilda: For your information, those seeking my help must make an appointment at least 15 days before the divination, otherwise, they won't even get to see me!

Sonetto: Haha.

Matilda: ...!

Matilda: ...

Sonetto: You were very serious during the divination ... Even your tone was different from usual.

Sonetto: However, I am more familiar with the way you talk now ... It reminds me of our time at school.

Matilda stands there, transfixed.

Sonetto waves at her and walks out of the room.

Sonetto: Thank you for making time for me, Matilda.

Sonetto: If you need my help next time, please let me know.

Sonetto: Good night.

The door is carefully closed behind her.

Matilda: ...

Matilda: ...

Matilda: !%$#...&*...

TO BE CONTINUED...

Divination Beginner

小径

Long Night Trip

A Sweet APPLe

4TH-11

A Sweet APPLe

Z: Richard, tends to oppose.

Z: Gloria, tends to support.

Z: Black Agate, tends to oppose.

Z: Ouzo, neutral.

Delegate: The situation doesn't look good.

Z: Do you have any news, Mark?

Delegate: Someone is spreading the minutes of your last meeting.

Delegate: I didn't get any direct evidence, but apparently every voter has read the anonymous minutes.

Delegate: The topic about Vertin ... It has become a great disadvantage to us.

Z: ...

Z: Double envelopment ...

Z: A "4-4 point double low approach" ...

Z: No wonder they let the draft go through so easily.

Z: To reject the draft during the committee meeting does not actually address the real problem. The House of Integratus can still re-submit the draft during the next legislative session.

Z: So she is planning for the long term ...

Z: To bring it down in the voting stage and make it a plan that is totally abandoned.

Delegate: I'm afraid so.

Delegate: A draft that has failed to win votes can hardly win the trust of the House's reviewers again, and of course it won't be submitted to the committee.

She counts the names on the whiteboard again.

Z: Did anyone make any actual move yet?

Delegate: Not yet. The minutes only changed their preferences, but the number of those who have taken a stand still remains the same.

Z: Hmm, just as I expected.

Z: This draft is not about Vertin, but a promise to the future—about how to balance the benefits between different interest groups.

Z: To reach that, we need to meet the expectations of those groups who have a need for flexible management, and also appease the conservatives and not shake their confidence in controlling the overall situation.

Delegate: Actually ...

The delegate adjusts his tie and interrupts Madam Z in a clear voice.

Delegate: We do have an opportunity to change the game now.

Z: Opportunity?

He puts in "0411" on the keyboard attached to his wrist, and turns on the big screen.

Committee member Pedra appears on the screen.

Committee Member I: I hereby challenge Delegate Mark Hal to a public debate on the revised draft of *Storm Reformation: Manpower and Discipline*.

Committee Member I: This draft of his will bring unpredictable risks to the Foundation, yet Mark himself seems completely unaware of it.

Committee Member I: I believe it is necessary to make such risks public in a legal way.

The delegate switches off the projection. As he turns to Madam Z, his cheeks have become rosy in heightened spirits.

Delegate: See, I knew they were going to escalate Vertin's issue.

Z: You want to accept this challenge?

Delegate: ... All the internal media are reporting the news.

Delegate: If I step back, they will definitely humiliate me and take advantage of the public opinion to undermine the draft.

Z: Mark ... That's a menacing move.

Madam Z picks up Pedra's name card and sticks it to the board.

Z: It is coming for us.

Z: No matter fight or flight, they have comprehensive preparation for this.

Z: I would suggest taking the long view and not jumping to conclusions.

Delegate: But defense without attack will never bring us victory, Madam Z.

Delegate: I've always wanted an opportunity to defend the draft in public.

Delegate: Concerning the questions they implied about Vertin, I've collected more than enough cases to refute them.

Delegate: Misleading questions twist people's opinions. It's time to tell them the truth.

The gaze behind Madam Z's glasses has become subtly piercing.

Z: You have accepted it.

Delegate: ...

Z: Was it in front of the media?

Delegate: I was there when Pedra challenged me ... so were the media.

Delegate: ... Well I don't think it is going to be a complete mistake.

The lady in white seems to loosen up for a brief second.

She doesn't say a word ...

... but walks up to him and gives him a pat on the shoulder.

Z: It is a crucial debate.

Z: Do your best.

Druvis Ⅲ: You don't have to come along with me.

Druvis Ⅲ: I'm here to repel the pests in the woods. It's part of my daily routine.

Sotheby: Thank you for your kindness, Ms. Druvis!

Sotheby: It is fun to stay in Ms. Vertin's suitcase ... but I really feel like seeing the world out there.

Sotheby: By the way, the pests you mentioned ... What are they?

Sotheby: I've heard of a kind of giant worm called the Tatzelwurm. They live in caves, about two to five feet long, and their heads are like cats'.

Sotheby: Be very careful if you see one. Both its skin and breath are toxic!

Druvis bends over, lifting a hanging branch to make a way for Sotheby to walk through.

Druvis Ⅲ: Heh heh. I have never heard of such a terrible worm.

Druvis Ⅲ: Hopefully we will not encounter any.

Sotheby jumps briskly over some roots crawling by her feet.

Sotheby: Hah, uh!

Sotheby: So what are we disinfesting this time?

Druvis Ⅲ: Oak processionary moths. Perhaps a few gray squirrel cubs.

Druvis Ⅲ: It's not enough to only rely on potions and arcanum to keep the woods in peace ... Oak trees reside here, and everything will change with it.

Druvis Ⅲ: Animals that live in symbiosis, fungi that depend on each other, all of them will embrace diversity by the day.

Sotheby suddenly looks up and points to the direction to the edge of the woods.

Sotheby: Do you mean that?

Sotheby: A group of grey fluff is flying over there!

Druvis looks in the direction her finger points to.

Clusters of fluff, in gray and brown, coming together and forming a flossy tornado in front of them, fly and dance in the air.

Druvis Ⅲ: ... A swarm of oak processionary moths!

Druvis Ⅲ: They are preying on something.

A fuzzy figure in red at the center seems familiar.

Sotheby: Ms. Druvis, let's help out right away!

APPLe: *sighs* ... This APPLe is deeply grateful for what you've done.

APPLe: I almost thought I was caught in a nightmare. This APPLe has never seen so many moths.

He is trembling from his stalk to the bottom.

APPLe: Ugh. This APPLe is going to have PTSD from insects.

Druvis Ⅲ: They are very sensitive to the scent of sap.

Druvis Ⅲ: With all due respect, even among all the plants, Mr. APPLe is quite attractive to insects.

Sotheby: So it was the scent that attracted them. No wonder Mr. APPLe's invisibility didn't work.

Sotheby: Thank goodness we are here!

Druvis carefully cleans off the fluff on APPLe with her handkerchief.

Until he restores his handsomeness.

Druvis Ⅲ: Mr. APPLe, did you find out anything?

APPLe: Yes, Ms. Druvis. I brought something insignificant.

APPLe: As we planned earlier, I disguised myself and reached the office building next to us.

APPLe: There is a device to detect arcane power at the entrance, however, this APPLe pried out what we needed from the guards.

Sotheby: What, what is it?

Sotheby: Did Ms. Vertin win on that voting list?

APPLe: Sadly, not yet.

APPLe: It's not time for a formal vote. Everyone is cautious and remains neutral.

APPLe: Apart from that, there are some rumors in the Foundation ... They are not very favorable to Vertin.

Druvis Ⅲ: Rumors ...

Druvis Ⅲ: It sounds as though the situation that Madam Z handles is more complicated and volatile than I thought.

Druvis Ⅲ: However, the votes have not been lopsided under such bad circumstances ...

Druvis Ⅲ: Perhaps that means the arcanists who share our aspirations are not in the minority.

APPLe: That said, I'm afraid we are starting a protracted war, Ms. Druvis.

Druvis Ⅲ: Yes. I know. I've taken an inventory of the supplies. We can still hang in there for four weeks and a half.

Druvis Ⅲ: Although they have cut off the water and electricity supplies in the building, we can still live on the resources in the suitcase for a while.

Druvis Ⅲ: There are fewer guards destroying the woods, probably because the abatis works.

APPLe: What worries this APPLe is that if the procedure to finalise the draft takes more than four weeks and a half, we would ...

Druvis Ⅲ: We would then survive by gradually shrinking our territory … until Madam Z's draft is officially approved.

Druvis Ⅲ: We have chosen the thorny trail, and so we are destined to burn our boats and never look back.

Druvis Ⅲ: Vertin … She is worth fighting for.

APPLe: For this point, Captain and this APPLe have absolutely no disagreement.

APPLe: Then this APPLe will keep scouting around for updates so that we could respond in time.

Sotheby: …

Sotheby's eyes are fixed in another direction.

Druvis Ⅲ: What are you looking at, Ms. Sotheby?

Sotheby: Over there … It feels like someone is staring at us.

Druvis Ⅲ: …

They both look over to that corner.

There is nothing but shadows. The darkness looks like a pond of unimaginable depth.

Druvis stands up.

Druvis Ⅲ: Let's go back.

Druvis Ⅲ: To the deep woods.

TO BE CONTINUED…

Trail ① Record of A Nameless Angler

小径

Sightings of the "Nameless Angler"

Sunday 07:21
Angelina of the Field Operation Squad passed by the east side of the Foundation Square and saw someone in white by the fountain.
This is the earliest sighting of the target.

Same Sunday 15:10
Mary of the Medical Department took stock of the Picrasma Extract III in the warehouse, behind which she found a rubber fishing bucket with 3 suckermouth catfishes inside which were 3-4 inches long.

Same Sunday 15:22
Mary left the warehouse and the fishing bucket was gone.
There were water spots and a little granite rubble left on the ground.

Monday 06:30-08:30
A cleaner found some abandoned fishhooks near the fountains as well as by multiple water sources (streams, estuaries). Most of the fishhooks were hung below treetops.

Same Monday 22:33
A patrol squad found a set of fishing gears near reception area 13.
The gear set includes a carbon fishing rod with woolen core, a foldable rubber fishing bucket, a comfortable folding chair, and three buckled boxes of baits made with Carbuncle's tooth pulp.
It is now taken to the Lost and Found.

* * *

All right, it seems to be a "Nameless Angler" in the Foundation.
We have collected some basic information after the first inquiry, but a lot still remain unknown.

What does he want? Where does he come from?
Is he a ghost? A spy sent by other political organizations? Or an arcane puppet made by someone that plans to wipe out all the suckermouth catfishes because they have a problem with the appearance of the race?
Everything, everything remains unknown ...
Hah! Let's move on to the next inquiry!

A Letter

4TH-12

A Letter

Committee member Pedra walks out of the changing room.

He sees Delegate Mark sitting in front of a mirror and shaping his sideburns into sharp summits with pomade.

A tie, ablaze with bright colors, is around his neck.

Committee Member I: Isn't that scarf a bit too high-profile?

Mark stops his beauty procedures and looks at Pedra in the mirror.

Delegate: I think it fits me just well.

Delegate: You chose a grey shirt. Wise decision.

Committee Member I: ...

Committee Member I: Looks like you're fully prepared.

Mark doesn't answer that question. Instead, he pulls out a volume of files and starts to draw and write on them.

Debate Moderator: Ladies and gentlemen, allow me to introduce the first debater of the day, Pedra Paul Gonzalez Rosa.

Debate Moderator: Graduated from the Law School of the University of São Paulo, he is a member of the committee and more importantly, the challenger of the debate.

Pedra lifts the curtain and steps onto the stage.

Debate Moderator: The other debater of the day is the delegate of the House of Integratus, Mark Hal. Over the past ten years, he has served the Foundation by drafting countless acts and conventions.

Debate Moderator: The topic of the debate today, *Storm Reformation: Manpower and Discipline*, is exactly a work of his.

Not one seat has been left empty around the debate stage.

Foundation Chamber

Madam Z's eyes follow Mark as he walks into the lights on the stage with a big smile.

The people on the stage are greeting each other. Madam Z takes off her glasses and wipes them again.

The chamber is filled with noises. The confrontation between the two sides in her blurred vision is a scene she has seen many times.

Debate Moderator: Alright, both sides are seated.

Debate Moderator: Before we start the debate officially, I suggest we give Mark the draft writer an opportunity to introduce the draft.

Debate Moderator: Would you please, Mark?

Delegate: With pleasure.

Delegate: *Storm Reformation* and its advocators believe in such a goal:

Delegate: In this ever changing environment smitten by the "Storm," this draft will help the Foundation win the trust of a considerable number of arcanists who have different backgrounds and abilities, in a more efficient and stable way.

Committee Member I: That is exactly where I must raise an objection.

Committee Member I: The draft has a huge risk which Mark Hal has not realized at all.

Delegate: No, sir. I totally understand what you're trying to say.

Delegate: You have put forward several questionable arguments to prove Vertin's suspicion of disloyalty.

Delegate: In response to that, please allow me to invoke the following cases to prove Vertin's competence for leading the unregistered arcanists.

Delegate: Please turn to page 373 of Vertin's personnel file. As you can see, since Vertin became the Timekeeper, the number of unregistered arcanists she has rescued so far is, 63.

Delegate: That is a number unmatched by that of anyone present. If that's not enough to prove her loyalty, let's continue ...

Committee Member I: I have to say, Mark, you have completely misunderstood my point of view.

Committee Member I: I don't care what Vertin has done.

Committee Member I: But the feasibility of the draft.

Committee Member I: According to the existing regulations, the duties of educating and disciplining unregistered arcanists are taken by the School of Discipline.

Committee Member I: While you suggested in the draft that Timekeeper's personal teaching would replace the current collective training ...

Committee Member I: Have you ever thought about the budget that we could possibly spend on it?

Committee Member I: The Foundation spends an alarming sum of money on education every year, and there is no way we pay extra for personal training.

Delegate: What, budget?

Delegate: Um, I don't see why we're talking about budget all of a sudden.

Delegate: Did you really read the draft? I didn't mention a word about budget ...

Committee Member I: Of course you didn't, which exactly proves you have never realized the risk I just mentioned.

Debate Moderator: Oh, it seems the real topic of the debate has just surfaced.

Debate Moderator: I believe everyone in the hall is looking forward to where it goes. So Mark, in terms of this point, we would like to know your real thoughts ...

Z: ...

She gets up, walking towards the entrance.

This is already a composition which the White would like to see.

Z: The Black stone is left there alone. That last move is also a defense in panic.

Z: If I were the player...

She gazes into the air, lost in her thoughts. She doesn't feel the gaze cast upon her from another direction.

Constantine is watching Madam Z from her corner.

As Madam Z walks to the entrance, somebody stops her.

A white item is handed to her.

And then ...

She disappears as soon as she steps out of the hall.

Constantine averts her eyes and looks back at the two debaters on the stage.

As soon as she has left the hall, Madam Z takes out that white note.

Z: What is it?

Secretary Sharon: Sonetto asked me to give it to you personally.

It looks like a simple, usual letter.

"Dear Madam Z,
With this letter I send you my best regards."

"I have been instructed to manage affairs on behalf of Timekeeper during her treatment."

"Please let me know if there are any missions to alleviate the situation. I will do my best to meet your expectations."

"Sincerely,
Sonetto"

Z: Good news.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Artificial Somnambulism Guidance

小径

Artificial Somnambulism Guidance (V2.0.16)

— Welcome Panel - 00101PL —

Welcome to the dream, arcanist.

... To enter the examination dream [Investigator's Stamina & Athletic Performance] ...

Touch the tip of your nose with your left forefinger,
and press the spot above your heart with your right ring finger and middle finger.
Hold the position for 3 seconds. When you feel heat in your throat or the middle part of your spine,
press the start button. [0/0]

... To enter the examination dream [Investigator's Practice of Arcanum Knowledge & Incantations] ...

Press the tip of your tongue against the roof of your mouth and
imagine something that makes your anxious or worried as specifically as possible.
When there are goose bumps on your skin,
press the start button. [0/0]

... To enter the training dream [Custom Mental Stability] ...

Clench your fists 3-5 times,
push the green button upwards by 1 notch,
and press the start button. [0/0]

... To enter the status simulation dream [Conventional Insight Tour] ...

Hold the afflatus medium or the relevant books you need,
swallow the vanilla mint provided by the device,
and press the start button. [0/0]

— New Feature Panel - 00102PL —

How to use the joint training dream [Tactical Cooperation]:

1. Make sure the distance between the two joint training devices is less than 25m and they are not separated by any
aluminium wares;
2. Make sure the two devices have the same mode, enemy number, weather and terrain;
3. ...
4. ...
...
6. Choose a reasonable mode according to your conditions.

Flashing Red

4TH-13

Flashing Red

Lilya: Oh. You're also here?

Sonetto hears her. She stops the practice.

Sonetto: Yes ... I am taking combat drills with the Artificial Somnambulism training system.

Lilya casts a sideways look at the screen in front of Sonetto. There shows her overall time length of practice.

Lilya: Six hours ...

Lilya: I'm not the only one goofing around.

Sonetto: No, I'm not. I am not goofing around.

Sonetto: I am waiting for orders.

Her face flushes scarlet.

Lilya initiates the machine in front of her, unaware of her awkwardness.

Lilya: Well, much luckier than me.

Lilya: I have so many things to bitch about ... "One who plays hooky." Have you heard it? Literally me.

Lilya: I should have turned down the offer when they promoted me to the Foundation headquarters. They don't have any field missions for a flying witch ...

Sonetto: Is it because of the provisions of *Talent Protection*?

Lilya: Only God knows.

Lilya: *House Arrest* may be a better name.

Sonetto: ...

She throws a casual glance at the screen.

Lilya: ...

Lilya: Look, since we're both bored to death, do you want to have a try at some difficult things?

Sonetto: What is it?

Lilya: Hm, this.

She pouts her lips, hinting at something which she thinks should be obvious to both of them.

Lilya: Have you tried the Artificial Somnambulism joint training?

Lilya: Put on the helmet together, and switch to multiplayer mode ...

Lilya: Two operators can take on a harder training mode ... more insane enemies ... Haha.

Lilya: Like playing in the arcade.

Sonetto stares blankly at Lilya as she operates the machines.

Sonetto: O-Okay. Shall I turn this red knob?

She is a bit worried, not sure what to do; she has to imitate what Lilya just did.

And she murmurs ...

Sonetto: ... What is an arcade?

The floor starts to vibrate as the machine goes into function.

The multiplayer mode has been initiated.

Lilya: What did you say? I can't hear you with my helmet on.

Lilya: Whoo, nice controller. Good! I'm entering the zone now.

Lilya: It's been a long time. Why not have some fun?

She quickly taps on some buttons, and the warning indicator on Sonetto's equipment suddenly flashes a red light.

Sonetto: The light is flashing ... What did you press?

Lilya: I switched it to the hardest mode! Haha! You better get it together!

Sonetto: W-Wait ...

But there's no time to "wait." Two words in big red font appear on the screen in front of them: DRILL STARTS.

Lilya: Don't fail me, top student.

The helmet has cut off their vital fluids and diverted them to a pre-programmed battlefield. The operators' vision is about to change ...

Sonetto: *breathing out* ... I am ... exhausted.

Lilya: Ha ... Almost choking.

They take off their helmets, slumping onto the floor together.

Sonetto: ...

Lilya: ...

Their gloves are soaked in sweat.

They subside into momentary silence, looking at each other.

They burst into laughter in high spirits.

Lilya: Hahahahaha ... hahaha ... I haven't had so much fun for centuries!

Sonetto: Heh heh ... Hahaha ...

Lilya: How many times did we die?

Sonetto: Sorry, haha ... I cannot do math now.

Sonetto: My mind ... goes blank ...

Lilya: Hahahaha ... who would expect THE Sonetto would have a brain fade ...

Lilya falls backwards, lying on her back, staring at the white ceiling with peaceful joy.

Sonetto leans on the wall, exhausted.

It was a fight of verve and vitality. All the noises that have been nagging them for days now seem to have disappeared.

There are only breaths, the wind, and the smell of the concrete floor.

Lilya: ...

Lilya: Have you heard the result of the debate?

Sonetto: I heard that ... the number of people opposing the draft significantly increased after the debate.

Lilya: Hm ...

Lilya: It's not going well.

Lilya: Soon will be the voting session. The opposition is taking the lead.

Sonetto: ... I hope Ms. Druvis can hold out.

Lilya: You visited them?

Sonetto: I submitted a request to enter that building ...

Sonetto: The system arranged guards to accompany me to ensure my safety.

Sonetto: The moment they entered the building, they started sawing the trees ... saying that they need to carve out the path.

Sonetto: Since then ... I have not been there.

Lilya: Four and a half weeks. After that, they can't hold on for any longer.

Sonetto: Really? In that case ... the vote result has to come out before that.

Sonetto is deep in contemplation.

Secretary Sharon: Hi, may the peace be with us.

Sonetto: ...!

Sonetto: Hello! May the peace be with us.

Secretary Sharon: Do you mind giving us some privacy?

Lilya: Do whatever you like.

They walk to the break room in the hallway.

Secretary Sharon: Here is Madam Z's message. Please visit her in the office on Friday.

Sonetto: Ah ... Okay. Copy that! Thank you for the message.

Secretary Sharon: With pleasure.

She nods and places her hand on her chest.

Secretary Sharon: Wish you a good day.

Secretary Sharon leaves the room at a quick trot.

When Sonetto returns to her exercise equipment, she finds Lilya is about to leave the room.

Sonetto: Are you leaving?

Lilya: Yes.

She picks up her gloves and the canteen but hesitates. She pauses for a brief moment, then quickly turns back to Sonetto.

Lilya: Do you know how the penalties for destruction of public property of the Foundation and brawl are determined?

Sonetto: ...?

Sonetto: Well, according to *Measures of the Foundation for Administrative Penalties*, based on the severity of the circumstances, fines will be imposed and the offender's salaries shall be deducted accordingly in minor cases, while detention or expulsion shall be imposed in major cases.

Sonetto: The penalty also depends on what is damaged. For example, production tools, household goods, buildings, equipment, facilities, etc. These are the properties that involve less cost and limited influence if damaged.

Sonetto: If the number of people involved in a brawl is equal to or less than eight, and there are no major casualties, the penalty will be minor.

Sonetto: May I ask what happened? Why are you asking this all of a sudden?

Lilya: Nothing. As I said, bored to death.

Lilya: So bored that I have been paying attention to the Foundation's regulations. Even the *Flying Manuals* failed to win this much of my attention.

She waves at her and leaves without looking back.

Lilya: So long, Sonetto. Hopefully there is good news for us next time I see you.

TO BE CONTINUED...

All-or-Nothing

4TH-14

All-or-Nothing

Delegate: We are falling behind even further. A vote or two won't help us turn this around ...

Z: I know.

Z: The move to D9 was indeed useless.

Delegate: The arcanists that were on our side have defected.

Delegate: I misjudged the situation in the debate ...

Delegate: I was going to seize the opportunity ... and the initiative ...

She doesn't respond to him, only pacing back and forth in the room.

Z: To seize the initiative ...

Z: ... may bring us the chance.

Thirty-eight lines go across the board in horizontal and vertical directions, crossing one another in 361 intersections as orderly as the stars.

Z: That is to say, don't pull back, don't jump ... even when they're attacking ...

Z: But to focus on the bigger picture, to win strong positions ...

She seems to have a sudden flash of insights, and reaches out one of her hands without being aware of doing so.

Z: The Black ... tsuke.

Z: Then ... the White hane. And the Black counter hane here. The White stand, the Black ...

Z: Osae.

Z: ...!

Z: Through these moves ... I see.

Z: The move to D11 can save us more than ten moku of stones.

Z: We can still win within ten moves.

Z: Mark.

Delegate: Yes? Are there any other things we can do?

Z: We need an influencer. A leader who can win us more than ten votes.

Z: Get me the files of the uncommitted leaders, including those who weren't neutral about this issue in the beginning.

Delegate: ... Okay.

He seems perplexed, but still quickly retrieves the files and starts browsing them on the chair.

The room is in complete silence except for the slight noise of flipping pages.

Delegate: Barzel.

Z: No. Too young to be convincing.

Delegate: Nonie, head of the Natural Resource Committee.

Z: There are only three of them in the group.

Delegate: "Center" Bernard, leader of the Mankind Caucus ... Ugh, forget it.

Z: Bernard?

Z: Yes, he can be our man. He is eloquent and leads a group of 11. All of the 11 are his loyal followers.

Z: Why is he uncommitted? I thought he would be the first to vote.

Delegate: Perhaps they believe it's a sure bet ...

Z: Find out what he's been up to.

Delegate: But Madam Z, are you sure you want to cooperate with him? This doesn't make any sense. We don't even serve the same group.

Z: Mark, we are all serving for the Foundation's future.

Z: I just want to know what he needs now.

Delegate: ...

Delegate: The office in Chicago, U.S.

Delegate: He is trying to cover that region with his influence.

Delegate: Bernard believes the employees there are guilty of serious dereliction of duty: they discriminate against humans of different classes and are suspected of committing electoral fraud in collusion with the local capitals.

Delegate: The Supreme Court's investigators have already intervened.

Delegate: But they cannot go out due to the "Storm" right now ... so the case is pending investigation.

Z: Chicago office ... I've read the reports on there ...

Z: I see.

Z: Great. Exactly what we can help with.

Delegate: Through what?

Z: Through Sonetto.

Z: I have a meeting with her on Friday ...

Z: This may lead us to a win-win situation.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① The Hardest Mode

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Legwork

小径

...

Choices

1. I just woke up. What happened?

2. I have no trouble. Don't come over.

Branch 1

That was a good sleep, dude. You drooled everywhere. Almost glued my eyelids.

You didn't expect there to be so many complicated, confusing factions in the Foundation—can't they just make this institution simpler so that people can tell one group from another easily, like telling the difference between cake layers?

Branch 2

Really? Dude, are you 100% sure that you are trouble-free?

I was sleeping like a baby, having a sweet sweet dream which has been long absent in my life. There were three ladies, a bevy of goofy swans, and I, living a harmonious life together in my dream.

Suddenly, a certain jinx woke me up, saying, "I have no trouble. Don't come over." How wonderful! I was like a stray dog sleeping on a square. You'll see, this old man is going to shovel all his complaints into your pure, innocent ear.

How do you feel about the structure of the Foundation? I can see your cockily raised neck, showing your attitude of rejection. Well, perfect! Let's start with this intriguing topic, then!

The Foundation is a mess. Listen up, it drifts along the chaotic swirl between order and disorder, enticing countless idealists and realists to come over.

The "Storm" exacerbates the chaos. Those arcanists who were snorkeling are now surfacing—You see, Ms. Z is a great example. She is even sitting at the same conference table with the human elites.

The undercurrents, however, are still lurking. Natural Resource Committee, Mankind Caucus, Culture and Education Department ... Their members are hard to differentiate given the intricate backgrounds. They bustled for benefits and mired in countless trivial matters.

You see? You need to divide them into groups, and divide and divide ... until you break a huge entity into small groups, as small as possible. That's when they are able to clean the vomit on the living room floor effectively and emotionlessly!

Shared continuation

Legwork

From the Ashes

4TH-15

From the Ashes

Follower I: Best wishes for the upcoming victory!

Follower II: It will be the final vote soon. It's a stunning victory for us ... Cheers!

Bernard: Cheers! May the peace be with us!

The group is fully immersed in the joy brought by the collective glory.

Z: You're in a good mood.

Follower I: ...!

Bernard: Z?

Follower II: You must be in the wrong room.

Follower II: You can't find those friends who tell balderdash here.

Bernard stops them with a wag of a hand. He pushes his way through the crowd and comes up to her.

Bernard: What brings you here, our honorable committee member?

Z: May I have a word with you, Bernard?

Bernard: Let me check my watch again. Hmm, it's three in the afternoon. I don't think I've drunk that much.

Bernard: Could you repeat that again?

Bernard: You want me, to canvass, for you?

Z: To be more precise, to form a partnership.

Bernard: My my, what a creative idea.

Bernard: What can you offer?

Bernard: Not supporting such a stupid draft next time?

Bernard: Or recruiting new arcanists for our caucus?

Z: What about a witness for the case of Chicago office?

Bernard: ...

He instantly frowns.

Bernard: Who is it? Give me the name.

Z: I will if you collaborate with me.

Z: Or talk to me with a better attitude.

Bernard: ... I'm sorry.

Bernard: Our philosophies have always been different, and that led to prejudice.

Bernard: But being mysterious won't show us sincerity for each other, right?

Z: A staff of mine is willing to testify as a witness. Her report can prove your point.

Bernard: Strong enough to prove their negligence?

Z: It depends on the special prosecutor.

Z: But the evidence is strong enough to prove that you're innocent from setting up others out of your personal interest.

Bernard: ...

He can't help breaking into laughter.

Bernard: Looks like you've got your own little bird.

Bernard: The management there sucks. They don't serve humans or arcanists. They are just puppets manipulated by money.

Bernard: I wanna bring order back to that place.

Bernard: And I've collected quite a lot of evidence against them.

Bernard: Yet the most ridiculous thing happened: in the second week after I submitted the investigation application to the Supreme Court ...

Bernard: The evidence was gone.

Bernard: My men found their charred pieces in the garbage room ... Someone threw them into the shredding incinerator.

Bernard: It was like I could do nothing but surrender.

Z: You have a wolf by your ears ... I understand.

Bernard takes a deep breath before he starts to talk again.

Bernard: But you're asking for too much.

Bernard: Eleven votes? We're on the opposite side. I can never persuade all of them to vote for you.

Bernard: Besides, the court session of the Chicago case starts later than the final vote ...

Bernard: Don't tell me you want the service before you pay for it.

Z: Don't worry. You can vote after testifying.

Bernard: How are you gonna do that?

Z: I will do what I can, in my power.

Z: The vote won't start so soon.

He raises one eyebrow.

Bernard: I can try for nine votes ... or ten.

Bernard: For the appreciation of your political resourcefulness.

Madam Z holds the hand waiting in front of her.

Z: Good luck making a better Chicago office, Bernard.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Contact Point

4TH-16

Contact Point

Unlike the other days, Constantine isn't by her desk today.

The light in the room stays off.

She has her back to the door, facing the window. Daylight slowly permeates into the dark room through the rigid marble windows.

Committee Member I: It's Pedra.

Constantine: Come in.

Committee Member I: I'm here to report the situation so far.

Committee Member I: Some neutral parties have tilted in favor of the draft.

Constantine: How many?

Committee Member I: Not a lot of them, but enough to make the votes even.

Committee Member I: They have always pursued revolution in the Foundation. Looks like Mark has finally persuaded them.

Committee Member I: I heard Ms. Z has been working hard on canvassing, too.

Constantine: ...

Committee Member I: But the number of the conservatives remains the same. We don't have to worry about that.

Committee Member I: I believe we will still prevail in the final vote days later.

Constantine: What about the other groups?

Committee Member I: Still functioning as usual, nothing special.

Committee Member I: By the way, Bernard and his men paid a visit to SPDM. I didn't get to talk to them.

She turns back to face the window.

Constantine: Thank you for the report.

Committee Member I: ...

Constantine: She has never been so persistent.

Constantine: Do you know why she's been so different this time, Pedra?

Sports Field of the SPDM

Committee Member II: I didn't realize you had time to invite me to play table tennis.

Committee Member II: Or ... are you actually here to lobby, Madam Z?

Z: Heh heh ... I'll say both, Katz.

Z: Back then when I was a student, I'd often invite my classmates to play ping-pong after we left the laboratory.

Z: A cold shower after getting soaked in sweat is a piece of memory I can't forget.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Heh heh ... you remind me of the old days in the table tennis varsity.

Committee Member Ⅱ: You're the only one I can practice with here.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Serve it, Madam Z.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Let's compete.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Hahaha ...! Backhand chop? Great, great.

She nimbly picks up the white ball and bows.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Again. Ready to go!

Z: Hey!

Committee Member Ⅱ: Nice shot!

Madam Z strikes. The little ball flies over the net in an extremely low parabola, and goes into the unguarded corner of the table.

Katz turns her body to one side, striking the ball back confidently.

Z: We're planning to revise some articles in the draft.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Which articles?

Z: The articles about strengthening the control of registered arcanists.

Z: You're right. We do need to improve the credibility of the Foundation in the outside world.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Tell me more.

Z: The Timekeeper's power to discipline should be transferred back to the School of Discipline and the Foundation.

Z: The Foundation will conduct a unified risk assessment on arcanists.

Z: To ensure this team is always under control.

Committee Member Ⅱ: But in fact it still belongs to the Timekeeper, right?

Z: That is our minimum requirement and it will not change.

Committee Member Ⅱ: Heh heh ...

Committee Member Ⅱ: I didn't expect you to compromise.

Z: It's not a compromise. It's a reasonable amendment to the draft.

Z: Transferring the power of education and discipline to the Foundation will help lower the budget and reduce the pressure on Vertin.

Committee Member Ⅱ: And you would even lobby an opponent, me, for this amendment.

Z: A reasonable appeal shouldn't be rejected just because it is raised by a different faction.

Z: The Foundation needs solidarity, not contradiction.

Z: If the draft is meant to pass, I will do whatever I can to make it meet most expectations.

Z: Just like this ping-pong game ...

Z: Friendship first, competition second.

Z: Legislation shall serve the people.

Committee Member Ⅱ: You have my vote, Madam Z.

Z: Heh heh ... A vote is not the only thing I need, Katz.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Ball Game

小径

Ping, pong. Ping, pong. Ping pong ping pong ping, pong. Ping. Pong.

Choices

1. It's too noisy.

2. An imitation show?

Branch 1

Yup. Agreed.

It's too noisy. You were looking at the little ball made of plastic. It hops from left to right, making an annoying sound.

But all we can do to it is look at it, just like all you can do to me is tolerate my existence, for both of us have nowhere to go.

Branch 2

Yes, an imitation show. A ball imitation show, little thing.

You're imitating the Messiah, while I'm imitating an orange ball made of plastic.

Being pushed back and forth by two rackets, I have nowhere else to go. Once they apply a force on me, I can't help bouncing to the sky. You can see how the air flows across my dry, wrinkled skin ...

Oh, what a coincidence! Aren't you in the same situation as mine now!

Ha! Look at your frowning face—

Your face wrinkles from the eyebrows to the nose tip, but people can barely see those light furrows. We know what that means. You have a poker face, and it's never your fault.

But for now, your face is not the thing that matters. Well, maybe for someone it is, but still, it's not.

You know what really matters?
The game! Yes, it's the game, of course the game matters!

Everyone loves the game. They gather at the stadium, yelling or roaring vehemently. They choose one team to become its fan and spend good money on a team uniform or an autographed ball.

Yet, it's just a ball. You see where I'm coming from?

Just a ball. Its outline, a circle, could be found in any geometry textbook and anywhere in this world.

When the first hominid picked up a coconut and threw it to the sky—and caught it—and threw it —and caught it—and threw it again, when she felt joy and yelped, had she ever thought of the future?

The future where a simple ball has become so complicated and enchanting, now we call it the present.

Choices

1. Complicated and enchanting?

Hahahahahaha! Yes, sure! Complicated and enchanting!

Use your silly and smart head to think about this ball game carefully.

The complex scoring rules, the harsh requirements for reactive agility, the countless possible foul points ... Your fingers, your wrists, and arms, a correct way of using them will lead to victory!

What matters more is, like every ball game, it focuses on how you serve the ball and hitting it back.

It's not an easy job as it sounds. When you are in the game, you need to concentrate. Where will the ball come from, and how will you return it to your opponent—you need to figure that out within half a second.

Use your power in a proper way, move your feet in a stable pace, inhale and exhale at the right timings.

Ping. Pong. Ping. Pong. Ping. Pong. Ping. Pong ...

The sound will last forever and ever until that bouncing little thing falls to either side of the court.

Shared continuation

Ball Game

Trail ② Fair Play

小径

The Opportunist and The Sticky Gum

Echoes in the Dark

4TH-17

Echoes in the Dark

Days later

Foundation Chamber

Chairwoman: Constantine.

Constantine, sitting behind the rostrum, looks up. She takes off her reading glasses and closes the book in her hand.

Constantine: Has the voting started?

Constantine: You see, here is the number of votes I have estimated. The pro-drafts will lose by five votes to their opponent.

Constantine: Don't forget our bet.

Constantine: The one who loses will pay for the new stamps.

Chairwoman: The final vote is not today ... I'm afraid.

She has a complicated look on her face.

Chairwoman: Z's speech is still ongoing.

Chairwoman: She has just started the part on Article 3, Section 5 of the rules of procedure ...

Chairwoman: But the speech has already lasted seven hours.

Chairwoman: Even some delegates have left.

Constantine: What ...

She smiles, surprised.

Constantine: A filibuster?

Chairwoman: Yes, and Katz's speech will be right after that.

Chairwoman: So I guess the final vote won't start until tomorrow.

Constantine: ...

Chairwoman: That won't make a difference. Delaying the vote won't change the result.

Constantine sighs.

Constantine: *sighs* We don't know yet.

Constantine: I didn't expect that she would be trying so hard.

Constantine: But for me, this is not necessarily bad news.

Constantine: The filibuster will only have two outcomes.

Constantine: It is either one of the parties wins over two-thirds of support and gains victory, or both parties get stuck in a tug of war.

Constantine: If this tug of war doesn't end with a clear outcome, the *Storm Reformation* will end up completely dead and forbidden to be discussed within five years.

Constantine: Are the stakes ... getting too high?

Someone trots over from the doorway. As he comes up to them, he bends over so that only Constantine can hear him.

Chief of Staff: Madam Vice President.

Chief of Staff: Mr. President came back from the Pax House.

Constantine: ...!

Constantine: I will go see him now.

Chief of Staff: He is waiting for you in the office.

It has been over a year since they last met.

Constantine quickly trots along the hallway.

The window is clear enough to give reflections. She stops and fixes her collar.

The door is left half open.

Constantine: Mr. President ...

Constantine: Good day to you, sir. May the peace be with us.

President: May the peace be with us.

Constantine: Are you feeling better these days?

President: I can still hang in for a few years. Thank you.

Constantine: Are they doing alright?

President: Just as usual. Nothing to worry about.

He gives Constantine a small wave in the shadow.

She walks up to him.

President: I'll stay in the Foundation these months.

President: The agenda is well arranged.

President: There is something more important that I must tell you in person.

Constantine nods, and bends over to listen.

The shadow of the president casts on her.

The rusty, feeble words are difficult to catch, but the meaning of every word makes her eyes wide open out of shock.

Constantine: ...!

Constantine: This, is their judgment?

President: Yes.

Constantine: ...

Constantine: Then ... I have no objection to it.

She slowly resumes standing, then retreats for a few steps and almost falls on the floor.

President: Hold tight, my friend.

She supports herself by the file cabinet.

Constantine: Excuse me.

Constantine: I have to admit I was surprised.

Constantine: Thank you for telling me this.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Dances with Fire

小径

Look at where you are. Paulina also once stood here.

Choices

1. Who is that?

A human. A member of the St. Pavlov Foundation.

She started from here, took 33 steps and a half, turned left, opened the door, and then turned right, went on for another 5 meters. She stopped and opened the historical intelligence cabinet.

Choices

1. What was she like?

2. Why was she there?

Branch 1

Human-like. A standard human. Grave-looking, rational-thinking, efficient-acting.

She was digging in the files. The only touch of bright color on her was across her neck—a blue polka dot scarf, tied in the French way.

The scarf was there to cover up a nevus on her skin. A lonely, dark spot that lacks a symmetric counterpart on the other side of the neck. It's a mark too random and out of place to exist. She did not like it.

Branch 2

For work, sweetheart. Most of the actions we took in most of the time were for our jobs, or for the sake of getting one.

She's a good employee, the kind of person who sincerely wishes to contribute to society. Her dedication to work equally applied to events as big as maintaining peace and matters as trivial as looking through old files.

It was the 1931 file, or the 1935 one. She hasn't gotten there yet. But there is another folder which has caught her attention.

On December 28, 1932, on the wonderful Day of the Holy Innocents in Mexico, 13 arcanist high school students attacked the crowd during the nighttime celebration.

They claimed the oracle had uttered to them, from the inside of a gigantic Cordia elaeagnoides, that they had to shoulder the responsibility to protect the people.

So they took their wands and knives, carried bottles of potion of concocted Picric acid and Nitrocellulose and walked into the festival market like any regular happy young people.

Their attack led to 17 deaths. Six were injured, among which four were disabled for life.

One young girl among the attackers couldn't physiologically stop her hysterical laughter even when she was under arrest. She quivered convulsively, with her hands twitching tightly on 31-cm-long pruning shears.

She kept muttering the word "Bocote," which is the common way to call the Cordia elaeagnoides among the lumber dealers. In the Aztec Civilization, it means "giant mouth."

"Any mouth can talk"—in this case of mass hysteria, this was the one true rule.

Hysteria, madness, paranoia, hearing voices or seeing things ... these abnormalities are the sparks flying in the air, and arcanists are like dry cotton. The encounter of the two ... will cause a fire.

Paulina complained quietly. She accused the danger of fire, the risk of heat. One can hardly hold no grudges against the flame, when it is hidden next to you, patiently waiting.

She started to mutter something of a more extreme nature. She was carried away—forgot that each individual has their own right even in a collective body. She forgot what public opinion can do to subtly influence a community. Her eyes were fixed on the scarlet flame.

Racist thoughts crept silently into her blonde-haired, beautiful head, like a cunning centipede.

Fortunately, this is not yet the end of the story. Paulina still had her chances to change.

Choices

1. To change?

Change. Yes. An alteration. Everybody has to change.

You can improve your living standards. Pay for prettier white clothes, drive around in a limo painted in bright pink—anything to prove that you are as much of a man as those tough warriors in ancient Europe!

Or you can try the bitter side of life. A life so bad that every weekend, you have nowhere to go but lie on a couch hollowed out by your dog and pick your nose. You pick it hard, just to locate and take out the hardest, largest booger that irritates your nasal membranes to stop the endless sneezing.

The change of Paulina started from a question.

A senior staff of the Foundation walked to her, flipping through the pages of the same folder, and asked, "But Paulina, how are you going to deal with the fire?"

On the next page, the survivors started a new life under the supportive measures, and the crazy children have left their poor family, leaving the violence and harassment behind, and moved into a sanatorium with white walls.

The record of the follow-up visits showed that they have stayed mentally stable since. They learned to calm themselves and overcame drug addiction and alcohol abuse. Some of them were even married.

Between the last two pages, there lies a thank-you letter. The names signed at the end of the letter went on for two lines, and the last name ends with a cheerful strike going up, like a smiley face.

“The fire is always there, Paulina. We need to find a way to live with it, not to extinguish it.”

“Keep them somewhere safe, like a high shelf, and away from the fuel. Watch over the temperature. Maybe teach them to burn in a manner that no one, including themselves, would be hurt.”

“Division and confrontation have never taken this world to a better place, have they?”

They went on talking for a bit more—about the responsibilities of this job, about personal liabilities, about hatred, about the minorities, about the practices that ought to be taken to realize ideas.

Young Paulina had changed. Drops of tears seep out from the bottom of that pair of beautiful green eyes.

I shed tears with her, of course. Sadly, I was busy sucking the flavoring powder on chips off my fingers and missed the right moment to wipe those tears off my face.

Nevertheless, this is my favorite episode ... We should watch it again! Ahem ...

... Look at where you are. Paulina also once stood here.

Shared continuation

Dances with Fire

Road of a Puppy

4TH-18

Road of a Puppy

Sonetto: As witness?

Z: Yes. Your report means a lot to him.

Sonetto: I ... I can provide the report, but I have no experience in court hearings ...

Sonetto: If I say something wrong, will it affect the special prosecutor's decision?

That's an unexpected question. Madam Z's voice turns gentle and soft after a moment of speechlessness.

Z: Sonetto, testifying is not taking exams. The court doesn't need a skillful witness.

Z: Just honestly tell them what you saw. Focus on the point and don't distort the facts.

Z: The Supreme Court ... they value the sense of justice of the youth.

Sonetto: Sense of justice ...

Z: And that's a noble quality you have.

Sonetto: I will do my best, Madam Z.

The meeting room

Special Prosecutor: Call the witness.

Entangled by the crowd, Sonetto walks into the court.

In front of her, the special prosecutor has an almost godlike solemn look on her face.

Sonetto: Greetings. May the peace be with us.

Special Prosecutor: May the peace be with us.

Special Prosecutor: Sonetto, as informed by the subpoena, you have been called forth by the accuser, Bernard Wilson, to testify as the witness in court. Could you specify the relationship between you and the accuser?

Sonetto: We did not know each other. I heard of him at work, but we rarely worked together.

Special Prosecutor: Then why did he call you?

Sonetto: I was one of the parties involved in the 1929 "Storm" incident. I submitted a detailed report of that. He searched the database and found the report, so he made a request for access to my supervisor, Madam Z.

Sonetto: Then, Madam Z asked if I would be willing to provide the report and attend court as witness.

Special Prosecutor: Could you tell me the reason why you agreed to testify?

Sonetto: I ... My immediate supervisor is having a long-term treatment, and there are more time slots available on my schedule.

Sonetto: I am happy to be able to make a difference during the time, and defend the established facts.

Sonetto: More importantly ...

Sonetto musters her courage and presents a box of files on the desk.

Sonetto: I, personally, believe that there is still much room for improvement for the Foundation's office in Chicago in the United States.

The special prosecutor seems slightly surprised.

Special Prosecutor: What is this? Ms. Sonetto.

Sonetto: This is a record of all my travels from the time I received the promotion order in the research center to go to the office in Chicago in the United States, to the time I went back to the headquarters of the Foundation when the "Storm" came.

Sonetto: This is the field report and diary I wrote about the "Storm" in 1929.

Special Prosecutor: What point do you make?

Sonetto: I would like to prove that the Foundation's office in Chicago in the United States violated the declaration "Fight for the Peace and Order of Mankind" and the rights of some humans and arcanists.

???: You are tarnishing our reputation!

Someone leaps to his feet on the other side of the table.

He is the assigned director of this constituency, the defendant of this court.

The Defendant: I request a debate duel. I won't allow her to distort the truth like this.

Special Prosecutor: Mr. Seth, I haven't checked these files yet.

Special Prosecutor: Silence, please.

The Defendant: Your Honor, you can examine the files one by one while we're having the debate duel.

The Defendant: I can't bear to see the long history of our office slandered in this way by a newcomer. I demand a duel with her.

Sonetto: ...

Special Prosecutor: Sonetto is an investigator with rich combat experience. There is no good dueling with her.

The special prosecutor turns to Sonetto.

Special Prosecutor: Do you accept the debate duel?

Sonetto: I have no objection, madam.

The defendant's neck has turned scarlet out of anger.

The special prosecutor stands up and raises both of her arms.

Special Prosecutor: Please, to the stage, duelists.

Special Prosecutor: The debate during your duel will be faithfully recorded.

Special Prosecutor: Three defeats in the debate of one side will end the duel.

Special Prosecutor: You have the floor now.

Sonetto: Schneider ... a friend we met in Chicago.

Sonetto: She once chose to join the Foundation under the pressure of both the "Storm" and Manus Vindictae.

Sonetto: But instead of offering any solution or help, you just gave her a rejection letter.

Sonetto: I found this letter in her suit pocket.

Sonetto: It had a small line written on it, "Paupers f**k off."

The Defendant: I-I had completely no idea what this was about ...

The Defendant: Not to mention the fact that no one at the office had ever heard of the "Storm" ... What help could they offer?

Sonetto: In this particular case, you should have reported to the headquarters or to the investigators out there, instead of doing nothing but leaving an insult.

Sonetto: I do not understand ... why there was such wording on it.

Sonetto: Was it because she did not pay enough "shelter fee" to qualify for sheltering?

Sonetto: Or was it because the wand she used was transformed by arcanum, which made you think she was an arcanist?

Sonetto: Does not the Declaration of Peace say "Everyone, strong or weak, rich or poor, of any race, deserves a helping hand so that the existing peace and order shall be maintained"?

The Defendant: ...

Sonetto: They were humans. If only they had made it to the headquarters sooner ... maybe ... they ...

Sonetto: ...

Special Prosecutor: In the particular circumstance at present, it's impossible for the headquarters to take in humans from all over the world.

Special Prosecutor: But you bring out a possibility, a possibility better than anything that happened.

Special Prosecutor: Thank you very much for your testimony, Ms. Sonetto.

Special Prosecutor: And also for the debate, Mr. Seth.

The special prosecutor and the jury get up, gathering the papers on the desk.

Sonetto's ears are gradually cooling off.

Sonetto: I seemed to be ... too emotional just now ...

She passes the hallway, feeling completely lost.

She feels the court session is not over, and she is still in the middle of the storm.

Special Prosecutor: Ms. Sonetto.

The special prosecutor stops her from behind.

Special Prosecutor: You brought us a great debate.

In the bright daylight in the hallway, Sonetto finally takes a good look at the special prosecutor.

This is quite an extraordinary face.

White, hard, and of a skin texture different from any creature's.

Special Prosecutor: Have you heard of the Supreme Court?

Special Prosecutor: You should come when you are free.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ①

小径

Déjà Vu

An undefiled scale,
Sitting high up in the hall of judgement,
with the listening ears, the sniffing nose, the watching eyes,
the raising brows, and the speaking mouth.
Being the well-polished, the bright, the spacious,
it is the dazzling daylight itself.

It is the carrier of a noble virtue,
as untouchable as the feathers on a bird's throat,
as unsullied as the unexplored snowy ground,
as undisturbed as the ripple-less milk in the glass.
I trust myself, that I have encountered such whiteness before, sometime, somewhere.

A Corner of the Board

4TH-19

A Corner of the Board

Constantine: I was told you have something important to share?

Chairwoman: Yes, the filibuster is about to end.

Chairwoman: Z told me they are going to end the speech and apply for the official vote at noon.

Chairwoman: If you are going to continue with the debate, don't forget to send your men.

Constantine doesn't reply. She glances at the delegates on their seats.

Constantine: Do you see Bernard over there?

Chairwoman: Yes.

Chairwoman: Quite a lot of his men attended today.

Chairwoman: They have remained uncommitted to Storm Reformation so far. I thought they wouldn't bother to attend ...

Chairwoman: The opposition side doesn't need a dozen more votes to win, after all.

Constantine: But the advocates of the draft do.

The chairwoman casts an eye on her, perplexed.

Yet Constantine doesn't intend to explain.

She looks weary.

Constantine: There will be a new draft given to you in two hours.

Constantine: I brought together a revision group last night with some hired experts. We have adjusted some of the articles in the previous draft.

Constantine: I will need you to present it to everyone when the time comes.

Chairwoman: What for?

Chairwoman: Is their draft going to be adopted?

Constantine: ...

The chairwoman looks ghastly. She can't help but ask again to confirm her suspicion.

Chairwoman: The draft is going to be adopted, isn't it?

Constantine: ... There are things that even I cannot manoeuvre.

Constantine: All I can do is bring benefits to as many people as possible.

Constantine: I have specifically made some amendments to the clearance to educate and discipline unregistered arcanists in section 3 on page 21, as well as the duties and obligations of the Timekeeper's special team in section 1 on page 40.

Constantine: Every arcanist assigned to the Timekeeper's department will be put through the Foundation's risk assessment and graded accordingly.

Constantine: Ordinary arcanists only need to receive primary Artificial Somnambulism training. The more extraordinary ones will be sent to the School of Discipline for re-education.

Chairwoman: Delegate Mark also submitted another edition which was quite similar to this one.

Constantine: Is that so?

She chuckles. It is a half-relaxed and half-bitter smile.

Constantine: Heh heh, well ... very well.

Constantine: I'm pleased we have reached a consensus even before we meet.

Constantine: Here are more things we have revised.

Constantine: Given their resistance to the "Storm," the Timekeeper's special team will take up more work related to Manus Vindictae.

Constantine: The Foundation will utilize their abilities.

She sits down on her chair.

Constantine: We have also fine-tuned the details.

Constantine: They will be given more executive power, while the Foundation retains control over all things.

Constantine: Remember, we have to make everyone aware of these changes before the voting starts.

Constantine: We have to make sure THIS version of the proposal is the one that gets the final approval in the end.

Chairwoman: Understood.

The chairwoman looks up. Lights shed on her reading glasses and give out a bluish white color.

Chairwoman: Can't believe this is happening ... Heh ...

Chairwoman: The first revolution targeting arcanists in the past decades ...

Chairwoman: Don't forget my stamps for this quarter, Constantine.

The right side of the hall is where the most eloquent people gather—the lecture area.

Madam Z stands on the podium. After the long speech lasting for days, she feels herself physically struggling to go on.

But her mind is getting clearer and clearer, more and more excited. Every cell in her body is ready to wake up at the very moment the voting starts.

She looks at the rostrum. Constantine is sitting next to the chairwoman calmly.

That is a strange calmness.

So strange that she is almost certain that she is watching Constantine place a piece on the bottom-right corner of the board.

Z: ...

Z: Am I so tired that my eyes are failing me?

Z: No. It's not the time to relax.

Z: Just two more hours. Hang in there. It will end soon ...

TO BE CONTINUED...

IMPORTANT NOTICE

小径

Interpretation of the Supreme Court concerning Some Issues on the Use of Filibusters

> Based on the current circumstances, this interpretation is hereby given in accordance with the relevant regulations and laws, in order to ensure the debates in the legislative process are carried out to serve its designated purpose, and the rights of the parties and interest groups involved are respected in the process.
>
> Article 1 During the legislative debates, any member of the Joint Committee of the St. Pavlov Foundation who has doubt on the bill itself and requires explanation has the right to request an open debate from the chairperson. The chairperson in charge of the matter is obliged to accept this request.
>
> ...
>
> ...
>
> Article 12 Within the 60 days of the legislative process and on the premise that all the parties are in compliance with the universally ratified Code of Conduct in the legislative period, both parties are entitled to an unlimited number of debates before the official voting on the bill and have the right to give up and withdraw from the debates.
>
> Article 13 Termination of speech by either of the two parties will be considered as their withdrawal from the debate. The debate will hence end and the voting on the bill will be initiated. If the other party requests to continue with the speech, the Supreme Court will approve the proceeding of the debate. The debate will then last until that party requests voting or withdraw from the debate.
>
> Article 14 Had no conclusion been drawn within 60 days, the Supreme Court shall determine the bill to be repealed. Any repealed bill will not be allowed to re-enter the legislative process within the next 5 years.
>
> Article 15 In 10 days after the debate starts, both parties involved will be allowed to request voting to end the debate.
>
> ...

Article 20 The filibuster is a special legislative process established for controversial issues. Any bill being put through the filibuster process will require two thirds of the votes of the Committee members' to pass. The Supreme Court will determine the bills which has less than two thirds of the votes to be repealed.

Picnic on the Lawn

4TH-20

Picnic on the Lawn

Regulus: Ah ...

Regulus: Roast leg of lamb ... Wellington steak ...

Regulus: Turkish kebab ...

Regulus: Ah ... I want meat ...

Sotheby: Hmm? Are you hungry?

Sotheby: Worry not, worry not. The leaves of the potatoes we planted have turned yellow!

Sotheby: Ms. Druvis said this is the harvest time! Let's dig them out and make shepherd's pie!

Regulus: Potato? Vegetable? ... No. I don't want them anymore.

Regulus: I've been eating healthy salads for a month!

Regulus: I want meat ...

Regulus: I want rich, juicy, meaty, sinewy, savory, sizzling meat!!

Regulus suddenly springs to her feet.

Regulus: Wait! ... It smells so good. That's meat!

Regulus: Where's that smell coming from?

Sotheby: Hmm ... I do smell something good as well ...

Sotheby stands on tiptoe, seeking the source of the incredible smell.

Regulus: I'll take a look!

Regulus rubs her stomach, grabs her bag, and dashes out.

Sotheby: Wait, Regulus! The critters' lair is over there!

Regulus: Critters?

Regulus: Haha, no worries! Critter is a type of meat! Roast it over fire and a square meal is here!

Regulus: Ah, it smells so good ...

Regulus: It's over here ...

She has gone.

Sotheby: Oh no, what can I do ...

Sotheby: Father said some critters could cause hallucination and diarrhea if eaten ...!

APPLe: What's going on, Ms. Sotheby? Why are you here walking around alone?

APPLe floats in the air and looks around them.

APPLe: Em, where is Captain?

Sotheby: Oh, good to see you here!

Sotheby: Regulus said she smelled meat ... and went straight to the forest to catch critters!

APPLe: ... Waffle!

APPLe: It has been too long since we last had Dr. Papper. Does Captain finally start to have a senior moment?

Druvis Ⅲ: Let's hurry over and take a look.

Druvis Ⅲ: The smell of food is unusual. It's verdant over there. There may well be other dangers lurking somewhere.

Regulus's figure appears among the trees.

The aroma of food has also become more intense.

Sotheby: This is weird. Where on earth does the smell come from?

Regulus is also looking for the answer to the same question.

She looks down, scrabbling in the weeds. As she goes through them, the weeds unexpectedly shake, out of which springs up a black shadow.

Regulus: Whoa!

Sotheby: Blimey, it's a Carbuncle! Regulus, it's not edible!

There comes another one.

One after another, until Regulus has an armful of angry Carbuncles.

Druvis Ⅲ: That's the lair of Carbuncles. They've been stirred up!

Regulus: Whoa ... a bumper harvest of critters ...

Regulus: Come and help!

APPLe: Hold on, Captain! We're coming!

Regulus: Oooh ... Are they really all inedible?

Regulus: I did smell the sizzling meat ...

Regulus: It's somewhere around here, right around ...

Lilya: Oh, hi.

Regulus: Whoaaaa—!

Regulus: Who are you?!

An athletic figure shows up from behind the bushes.

Druvis Ⅲ: Lilya?

Druvis Ⅲ: What are you doing here ...

Lilya throws her bag at their feet ...

A roasted leg of lamb, wrapped in tinfoil, falls out of her bag.

Lilya: I got you something good.

Roasted pork knuckle, farmers sausage, black forest ham, some unknown drinks, leba bread, leba bread, and leba bread.

Regulus: Whoa—!

Regulus pulls out the lamb as quickly as a flash and devours the meat.

Regulus: Ah! Lamb! It tastes so good ... sooo gooood! I barely know what grease is supposed to taste like ooooooh ...

Regulus: *chewing* ... Thank the great god of rock for his blessings! This Pirate finally gets some meat to eat!

Lilya: Huh? It is me you should thank, the goddess of victory who soon brings you freedom.

Druvis Ⅲ: Bring us freedom soon? May I ask ... how should I interpret your words?

Lilya: Heh heh.

Lilya sits down on the ground.

She opens one of the cans and pours the drink into her mouth.

Lilya: You want some?

Druvis takes the drink from her and takes a sip.

Druvis Ⅲ: Thank you so much for coming alone and providing us with supplies, Lilya ...

Druvis Ⅲ: However, please tell us why you are here.

Druvis Ⅲ: ... Did Madam Z send you?

Lilya shakes her head. She gives out four fingers.

Lilya: Already been four and a half weeks. Right?

Lilya: This is not the first time I visit you guys here.

Druvis Ⅲ: ...!

Druvis Ⅲ: The one hiding in the shadow last time ... It's you?

Lilya: I wonder how much longer you can hold on for Vertin.

Lilya: You see, saying is one thing, fighting is another.

Lilya: I've seen many deserters. Way too many.

Lilya: Crying out loud, peeing their pants, drooling all over on their rabbit foot ...

Lilya: But you guys are different.

Lilya: You actually did it. You conquered places in the Foundation, defended your own places, and put pressure on those in white till this day, the last day in this four weeks and a half.

Lilya: That's the iron will I appreciate.

Lilya: And if I didn't come today, would you eat your boots tomorrow?

Regulus: Of course not. We still have potatoes. Almost ripe.

Sotheby: And carrots!

Lilya: Hahahahaha!

Druvis Ⅲ: Thank you for your kindness, Ms. Lilya. May I take it that you are coming to bring us the good news?

Druvis Ⅲ: Is there a final result for Madam Z's draft?

Lilya: So far as I know, Madam Z hasn't given up yet.

Lilya: Just like you, when she gets serious, she looks like a fierce doe.

Lilya: But I already lost my patience.

Lilya: Tons of "processes" need to be done before it can be performed, even if the draft is passed at the final vote.

Lilya: As long as Vertin is still on that bed in the ward, you are just an isolated island.

Lilya: Everyone can step on you.

Lilya stands up and pats off the dust on her carelessly.

Lilya: "Take care of them for me when necessary."

Lilya: That's what Vertin said when she gave me the vodka.

Lilya: It's time to deliver on my promise.

Druvis Ⅲ: Are you going to do something dangerous?

Lilya: A thing that is worth the risk.

Lilya: I've been waiting for this moment for so long.

Lilya: Someone needs to wake up from the dream.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① Outside the Spotlight

小径

The story has come to a new stage.

It is fascinating. It has plots of unwavering loyalty, survival from the jaws of death, and even a little bit of ... unconventional excitement!

Raise your head, and you will see this splendid spotlight grilling the top of our heads like a stove heating a frying pan.

We mumble, and mumble, and mumble ... something like arcanists, new changes, perseverance, and the "Storm." Right, that's it! The "Storm"!

The "Storm" is no longer something new here. Everyone in the story talks about the "Storm." People don't find it attractive anymore.

Once you turn the camera out of the spotlight, you'll see many other people on the stage. Many, many other f*****g people.

Choices

1. Who are they?

2. Where do they come from?

Branch 1

The other actors. Actors who are different from you.

Their name won't be listed in the cast at the end of the movie. Not even a poor "St. Pavlov Squad Leader A."

Branch 2

Neat question. People always need a place to come from.

Then I will give you a neat answer as well, you inquisitive little thing. They came from their mothers' tummies. Can you understand it? Is it too difficult for you?

They're a bunch of people, a bunch of people just like you, though there are still differences between you and them. Open their bellies, and you can find everything that should be there—the liver, the stomach, the spleen, the lungs, and the heart.

Their faces are clear to be seen. Look at them carefully, carefully. Oh, you might have met one or two of them.

They come from the same institution as yours, the St. Pavlov Foundation.

Eve from the France branch, La from the Egypt branch, and the Matryoshka from the Russia branch.

Oh right, your first friend made in a branch, that—that young man with a red nose—Ken! Ken from the Scotland branch. You looked here, you looked there, you couldn't find him anywhere, however hard you tried.

Choices

1. Where did he go?

Good question. I'll help you find him.

Let's keep looking around, but this time, vertically instead of horizontally. That's right! Upside vertical. Don't be afraid of that radiant spotlight, look there! Ignore the risk of blinding your eyes!

And you see it. A white umbrella, bigger and wider than any umbrella you have seen. Those green flashes stinging your eyes is the price you have to pay for finding it.

The white umbrella is a shelter from the rain, saving that Orange-hair girl in white for you.

And you have witnessed how people standing in the pouring "Storm" without shelter fade away.

Like your little friends, and Ken from the Scotland branch.

Remember the differences I just mentioned?

Choices

1. ...

A great time to keep silent.

Your ugly trauma, a mixture of your mental issues and miserable past, would burst out in the next second, making everyone's heart twitch.

But think otherwise.

If the truth were known to all—today's not real, and there's no tomorrow, I'm going to eat my shoes, and an asteroid is falling—then all of them would go crazy.

Those "pigeons" valuing sense above anything won't sit aside and let this happen.

So they made the most sensible choice. The huge white umbrella has only sheltered those qualified people. "Qualified" according to their standard.

Now, let's cross our arms and make an arrogant judgment like those cynics, "How cruel it is!" And then, you may start contemplating.

Should they all go aboard the ark? Can this ark carry these many people?

Try to raise the question as peacefully and slowly as you can. And their enthusiasm will be dampened and let out a sound like what you hear when you pour water into a heated pan—sssss ...

Choices

1. ... What about their feelings?

Their feelings. Oh, they! You mean Eve, La, and the Matryoshka! Of course, you care about your friends. That's a virtue of yours I won't forget.

In order to understand their feelings, you need to bend down and reach. That's right, reach for the dark corner under the stage.

Until your fingertip is wrapped by soft, warm, and considerate black velvet, as comfortable as a mother's singing to her baby in a crib.

That's what the people without a shelter above them are feeling now.

Choices

1. ...

More silence. You are really good at finding the right timing for your silence, just like my friend and I are experts in farting soundlessly in the elevator cart.

My hypocrite and dumb friend, think about it in a different way.

Who knows how much garbage there is under the stage? There may be liquid seeping out of rotten pastry and dairy products, intrusions of American cockroach with sleek abdomen crawling everywhere ...

Who can say it's not a blessing to know nothing about the truth?

Especially when you can't leave this shitty place.

Shared continuation

Outside the Spotlight

Good Weather

4TH-21

Good Weather

Chairwoman: Final round of the vote.

Chairwoman: Voters, please hurry up.

Chairwoman: One minute to go.

Mesmer Jr.: ...

Chairwoman: Please be responsible to your votes in every round.

Chairwoman: Vote as soon as possible.

Debate Moderator: The draft-avocates have more votes now, but they still need more than that to meet the supermajoritarian requirement.

Mesmer Jr.: What ...!

Chairwoman: Please vote now.

Chairwoman: Thirty seconds to go.

Chairwoman: Final countdown.

Chairwoman: Ten seconds to go.

Chairwoman: This will be your last chance to vote. Please hurry up!

Chairwoman: Voting closed.

Chairwoman: Storm Reformation: Manpower and Discipline passed.

Mesmer Jr.: ...!!

Lilya: Bucket list, one less!

Lilya: The glass is not as hard as I thought.

Lilya: Hey, time to wake up, Vertin.

Vertin: ...

Senior Guard: What's that sound? What's going on?!

Staff staying outside the ward rush into the room.

Lilya: That was a quick reaction.

Lilya: Один, две, три ... Well, relax. I'll keep the acceptable damage under eight.

Mesmer Jr.: What ... w-what is this ...

Mesmer Jr. crouches next to the stool, rubbing her hands aimlessly.

The staff are putting on well-designed helmets as they come in.

Senior Guard: Everyone, get your gear, formation one ...

Senior Guard: Capture the intruder!

Lilya: Hahaha! Bring it on! Let me have my dear long-lost real fight!

Lilya: Heh ... heh heh ... hahaha ...

Senior Guard: Emergency! Room 1525 calling for backup!

Lilya whisks away his walkie-talkie.

Lilya: Hey, no backup! I need to strictly follow the damage control standard.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: L- ... Lilya ...?

Lilya: Finally awake?

Lilya: Nice, time for us to leave.

Lilya: Come here and sit on the broom ... yes, behind me ... Grab tight! Don't say I didn't warn you if you fall down and die!

Vertin: Urgh ...

Neither the mind nor the body is responding to her calling.

No reaction can be given to what is happening.

She only knows to grab the handrail tightly.

The metal handrail feels cold and hard. This is the result of everyone's effort.

Lilya: Alright, Red 38, let's go!

A strong shake.

Senior Guard: Mesmer Jr., Mesmer Jr.! What are you doing?! They are running away! Go ... Get them!

Mesmer Jr.: *sobs* They are, mad people ...

Lilya: Save your whining for Constantine!

The broom rises into the air.

It doesn't waste a second to pause, flying towards the open windows.

The dazzling, glaring white light—so strange, but also so familiar.

Warm wind blows in through the window.

It's a cloudless, sunny day outside.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: What good weather.

Vertin: My friends.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① A Clipping of Old Newspaper

小径

A Clipping of Old Newspaper

What Does Abstained Vote Mean And The Necessity of Abstention Ballot Box

Abstained Vote is one of many forms of protest votes.
It usually turns up next to an empty seat, inside a dustbin, between the washing machine and the wall, in the middle of a book, or in one of the inner pockets of an old jacket. It is the invalid vote cast because the voter has abstained from voting, and thus would not be counted into the election result.

Different from other reasons which caused failure to vote, voters cast abstained votes because they neither approve nor disapprove of the available options of the voting. They may have swung between different answers, or even were once slightly more in favor of one motion/ candidate over the rest of them, or hold a pessimistic opinion to all the options provided; whatever the reason might be, in the end, they decide to not support any motions/candidates in the election.
Many have also argued that abstention from voting is, in fact, an action guided by a clear awareness of their given rights. As the subjects of rights, voters are entitled to the freedom not to vote.
It is also argued by the same group of scholars that, when the voters are requested to choose between unfavorable options, it takes courage and determination to stay true to their own ideas and become the dissidents in this case. Such action is worthy of praise. They are individual thinkers who know what they need and are strong enough not to compromise.
The Abstention Ballot Box is specially set up to count the votes of this group of people. It stands for a new possibility, a new way to the yet unknown solution to the problem, a relatively bumpy path compared to the easy way. Those who know its value and seek for the difficult path will eventually find their way in, and along which they shall find places they truly belong to.

The New York Daily Jan 19th, 1961
Written by: John Greymirror Brown

Returning Birds

4TH-22

Returning Birds

Lilya: How do you feel?

Lilya: Getting used to the light?

Vertin: Hmm ...

Vertin: The wind feels ... so good ...

Lilya: Haha, this is just an appetizer. I'll be gentle since you are just "discharged."

Vertin: Are they alright?

Lilya: Good as new.

Lilya: They stayed up all night, just to save you.

Lilya: Haha, I guess you are the only one who has slept tight.

Vertin: Haha ...

Lilya: Madam Z, Druvis, Sonetto ...

Lilya: From the bill, and the protesting, to countless debates, planning and ...

Lilya: Everyone is holding their umbrellas for you, Vertin.

Vertin: ...

Lilya: The "Storm"...

Lilya: It will pass, one day.

Vertin: Thank you. Thank you all.

Vertin: Yes. Everything is going to be alright.

Lilya: Enough flying. Time to head back.

Vertin: What are we doing next?

Lilya: Hmm ... no idea. Meet your friends first.

Lilya: Fight with your comrade in arms, fear no danger ahead.

Lilya: Grab tight, I'm going to speed up.

The wind flows through them like waves.

Lilya: Charge! The great Red 38!

Lilya: Long live Su-01BE!

Druvis Ⅲ: How are you feeling? Better now?

Regulus: *coughs* ... It's ... it's killing me ...

APPLe: Here's water! Captain, sip, please. Don't put too much pressure on your esophagus.

APPLe: *sighs* This APPLe told you not to swallow leba in haste ...

Regulus: *drinks water*

Regulus: Ah ... *coughing* ...

Regulus: I'm ... I'm alive ... Ah ...

Regulus: Oooh, I thought I wouldn't be able to see the sun tomorrow or see Vertin discharged!

Choices

1. You will.

2. Why are the leba bread here?

Branch 1

Regulus: Who's talking?

Is it because they have been apart for too long?

Or is this an illusion generated by their longingness?

They turn around in slow motion, straining their eyes.

Regulus: Vertin!!!

Regulus: You're back!

Branch 2

Regulus: Because Lilya—

Regulus: Wait, whose voice was that ...

Regulus: Is it ...

Mixed feelings turn into tears running out of her eyes. Is it out of shock, or ecstasy?

So many struggling days and nights.

This is the finish line of desperation. Ahead of them, hopes await.

Regulus: Vertin! You silly git!

Regulus: Now you come back!

Shared continuation

APPLe: Vertin!

Druvis Ⅲ: Vertin!!

Sotheby: Vertin!!!

Regulus: Whoa ... *sobbing* ...

Druvis Ⅲ: Are you feeling okay? There was a lot of equipment connected to you ...

Druvis Ⅲ: Do you feel any discomfort?

APPLe: Do you need any nutritional supplements, Ms. Vertin? We have a lot of healthy, fresh salads here ...

Sotheby: Where did you come back from? What are all these white pigeons doing after you?

Sotheby: You seem to have gained weight ... No no, lost weight? Um, no ...

Vertin: I'm fine. Fit as a fiddle.

Vertin: Just a bit of headache, nothing else.

Vertin: It's good to see you again.

Vertin: Thank you for being here ... being around me.

Regulus wipes her face on the coat in front of her.

Regulus: ... Of course!

Regulus: Of course we ... we're waiting for you!

Regulus: You're the only ... friend we have in this world!

All the waiting has been worthwhile.

In the meantime, footsteps come from a distance.

Footsteps of well-trained, strong soldiers.

Constantine: Welcome back, Vertin.

A figure in a white robe emerges in the woods.

Constantine: We have good news to share.

Vertin: ...!

Next to her, stand Sonetto, Madam Z, and some unfamiliar faces.

The moment their eyes meet in the air, Sonetto opens her mouth—but she eventually doesn't speak a word.

Sonetto: ...!

Sonetto: ...

Sonetto: ... This is good. This is great.

Vertin: May I ask what good news?

Constantine: The passage of the bill—*Storm Reformation: Manpower and Discipline*.

Constantine: Once it's approved by the Pax Security Council, it will become law.

Constantine: Your friends and you will enjoy more autonomy, and a life with even fewer restrictions.

Constantine: You will also have a more respectable status in the Foundation.

Vertin: ...

Constantine: Ms. Z will fill you in with more details.

Vertin: Thank you for telling me this.

Lilya, who has been quiet by their side the whole time, suddenly speaks up.

Lilya: What about the treatment?

Constantine: Treatment?

Constantine: Didn't it finish just now?

Constantine: This treatment has an investigative purpose, and the Timekeeper has passed the examination as a safe, low-risk individual. As Ms. Z has said, Ms. Vertin is strong enough to be the Timekeeper.

Constantine: However, you will receive punishments for the damage to public property. I suggest you heed it as a warning.

Lilya: ...

Constantine waves to the crowd. The rest of them are about to leave.

Constantine: We should say our goodbye. Please rest well.

She suddenly notices the white dove on the tree and stops.

Constantine: Hmm, seems like the dove of the white marble house is paying you a visit.

Vertin: What do you mean?

Constantine: Heh heh ... Nothing peculiar.

Constantine: It just means you have come to their notice.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Trail ① The Song of A Puppy
小径

The Song of A Puppy

I once looked down at a brave young dog,
It was gallant, the most courageous of all.
It wears a hat in piebald, and has eyes of emerald.
The first-magnitude stars sprinkle on its spine. Its tail was as green as the moss.

It was once asleep, once hungry, once afraid, once in tears,
once an umbrella, once a tree,
once a jumping coat rack and a ship
Oh, but then, but then --
It's again the brave young dog. Loyal and gutsy, it walks among the hearts of gold.

Old Days Once More
4TH-23

Old Days Once More

This is the end. Everything has been settled.

Time flows by like water flows over a perfectly flat plain.

Z: Yes. That's right. En, I got it.

Z: I'll reply tomorrow.

Madam Z returns to her office as usual.

But this time, the secretary, who always fully engages in the daily agenda, looks up to her.

Secretary Sharon: Please wait, Madam Z.

She passes her a box.

Secretary Sharon: Madam Constantine asked me to give this to you.

Z: Did she say why?

Secretary Sharon: No, she didn't explain it.

Sharon quickly goes through her head.

Secretary Sharon: Wait, I think she mentioned ... it's September 11 in the Chinese calendar today.

Z: ...

Z: I see. Please send my thanks to her.

Sharon nods and quietly returns to her seat.

Madam Z looks at the box.

A faint smell of red sandalwood wafts in the air.

A set of brand new Go.

A gift card is attached.

Constantine: "I'm glad to witness your progress."

Z: ...

Madam Z closes the box calmly and puts it into her pocket.

She opens the door and walks into her office.

She looks around.

This is just an ordinary room. Normal, but practical.

There are regulation documents, academic journals, and calendars and agendas. An old photo is placed next to the mirror.

She sees herself in that mirror.

The face in the mirror is a lot more mature than the young girl in that old photo.

... Will a doe become a tigress?

She runs her hand through her hair.

It doesn't seem too long ago when she still had a braid to her shoulder.

She combs her hair and splits it into three strands.

Lay the leftmost strand on top of the rightmost, go across, then the right goes on top of the left, cross, and tie it up.

The braid bristles, like an awkward sheep tail.

Z: Heh heh ...

She opens the refrigerator and takes out a plain cake under the cold light.

With a tight pull, the lamp turns off.

The room quiets down again.

Happy birthday to you, happy birthday to you.

May the good luck go with you. Happy birthday to you.

blows out the candle

THE END